

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Demo(n)Tapes

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Short summary of applied tools and link to project 1 video

Tools used:

Engine: Unity 6000.2.6f1

Language: C#

Programming environment: JetBrains Rider

Version Control: GitHub Desktop + Git

Graphics:

- Krita
- NewArc.ai (AI-assisted sketch-to-image concept visualization tool)

Audio: FMOD Studio, Reason Studios Reason 13.x + Reaper, arsenal of VST plugins, basic band instruments, some other instruments

Design assistance: ChatGPT (OpenAI GPT-5),

Code/Documentation analysis: JetBrains AI Assistant (within Rider IDE)

Also add a link to the explanation video as instructed for Project 1 as a separate link:

[<link to video here>](#)

<https://youtu.be/GN7YdcE7EFs>

Game Design Document

- Define your own game idea with minimum of 1-3 sentences per point.
- Consider the developed game from the viewpoint that you are making something which will be published at the end.
- Focus on the aspects 1-4, others you can define in more general terms since this is only the intro course into game development.
- The main aspects you are defining here are the following:
 - What would you like your game to look? Search or draw some concept art for your game, levels and characters.
 - What is the player doing in the game, what are the abilities of the characters?
 - What technological demands or requirements do you have? What technical aspects have to be solved for your idea to work?
 - What will your interface look like? What control scheme are you using and how does it work?

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1. Executive Summary, Quick overview

On the usage of the words TRVE, trve, and KVL T

*The game distinguishes between **trve**, **TRVE**, and **KVL T** as separate but related concepts within the simulation of the scene.*

- **trve** refers to surface-level conformity: alignment with the currently accepted aesthetics, trends, and expectations of the scene. It is reactive and imitative and can be achieved without structural or ideological depth.
- **TRVE** refers to a mechanical validation of authenticity. It is produced through a valid ideological contradiction (a re-sacralising tag-pair) that has been properly activated. TRVE is not a matter of taste or consensus, but of structural legitimacy within the system.
- **KVL T** refers to the current canonical state of the local scene, as defined by the Scene Nexus. It is the reference frame against which both **trve** and **TRVE** are evaluated. While initially rooted in a specific black metal orthodoxy, KVL T is not fixed; it evolves over time through canonization events and Keeper intervention.

The stylization of these terms serves to prevent ambiguity with generic language (such as the boolean “true”) and to reinforce their distinct mechanical roles.

*To further emphasize the distinction in tone: when encountering **trve**, one may imagine the distant roiling of thunder; when encountering **TRVE**, a sharp clap of lightning. **KVL T**, by contrast, is the storm itself—the shifting atmospheric condition within which both phenomena occur.*

Demo(n)Tapes is a game inspired by the emerging 2nd wave black metal scene of the early nineties, set in a fictitious amalgam of all Nordic countries called Snordenmark (postal hyphen “SNO”), located in the middle of the Atlantic (roughly around where Iceland should be). It is also an art project that seeks to embrace both the DIY-spirit of the scene it simulates, and the anti-establishment attitude prevalent in it.

Each player controls a band leader visionary (this is an online multiplayer game), who manages their own band amidst a larger clique of metal heads, surrounding a record shop (called The Hole) with rapidly changing management at the capital city of Snordenmark. The game is played in rounds and turns (called years and seasons). The objective of the game is to nurture both the sound of what is considered TRVE

within KVL T, and the sound your band is directly contributing to KVL T, by participating in it through creation of demos, keeping those aspects that you have created and working against the elements that reinforce other players' influence within KVL T. A victory in Demo(N)Tapes is simply a score that is greater than that of other players', but the entire score board of a session scales up if the scene is kept healthy and vibrant (or perhaps Grim and Morbid).

Actual success is measured against the dualism of authenticity and homage. Authenticity represents street credibility and purity of intent, while homage represents co-operation within a system that is always looking for an excuse to exclude the player. The player who is currently ahead is called the Keeper, and they are automatically put in charge of the record shop with all its services. When in charge of the record shop, the player cannot produce new material but must instead use their authority and other, subtler means to influence gameplay in their favour.

A game of Demo(n)Tapes ends after a cataclysmic end-game event happens, towards which the game engine pushes the events in an organic fashion. The KVL T bubble might burst, ending the authenticity striving creation and replacing it with a formulaic and rigid type metal music emulating the last great bands. Or alternatively, such a drastic set of actions is taken in the name of authenticity, that the societal backlash simply wipes the scene away.

The project acts as a prototype for Scandinavian Extreme Metal Manager '91 (SEMM91), a future expansion (or the actual version 1.0), where the player manages their band in a *single player campaign*, with record labels, live gigs/tours, illegal notoriety operations and other such elements introduced. As it stands, Demo(n)Tapes is an online multiplayer game with limited features only.

2. Prototype Scope for Thesis Version

Purpose

The first playable prototype of Demo(n)Tapes demonstrates the core gameplay loop and semantic system, while providing the necessary mechanics to complete a counterculture simulation.

The prototype validates:

- the gestation → rehearsal → release loop
- the TRVE vs trve distinction
- the basic scene influence model

Core Player Experience

Each player controls a band leader (Controller) and manages a small band.

A game progresses in turns (seasons):

1. The choice of a collective stance
2. Performance of character actions
3. End turn → scene updates

The player's goal is to:

- create demo tapes
- circulate them
- gain influence within the scene

Included Systems

1. Turn Structure

- 1 Year = 4 Turns (Seasons)
- Each turn:
 - Select Stance
 - Perform 2 or 3 actions

2. Collective Stances (3 in total)

Gestate

- Acquire tags from locations
- Combine tags + aspects → ideas

Rehearse

- Combine ideas → tracks
- Improve conveyance (clarity)

Promote

- Release demo tapes
- Increase visibility / scene presence

3. Simplified Tag System

Reduced from full design to 3 axes (prototype subset):

- Sacred ↔ Profane
- Raw ↔ Honed
- Morbid ↔ Vital

Each idea:

- contains 1 tag or tag-pair

Each track contains at most 4 ideas.

4. TRVE vs trve (Core Mechanic)

- **trve** aligns with current scene trends
- **TRVE** contains an active tag-pair (dominant-submissive contradiction)

Rules:

- Tracks without tag-pairs are trve (score only)
- Tracks with activated tag-pairs are TRVE (score + influences scoring logic)

5. Track & Demo Creation

Pipeline:

1. Gestate → create ideas
2. Rehearse → combine ideas into tracks
3. Record → create demo tape (C-cassette)

Each track has Tags and a Conveyance score (0.00 – 1.00)

6. Scene System (Simplified)

The scene is represented as:

- A shared space of released demos
- Each demo has:
 - Visibility (how widely it spreads)
 - Influence (impact on scene)

Influence depends on:

- TRVE status
- Conveyance
- Promotion

7. Basic Circulation

- Demo tapes are distributed to connections
- No complex copy degradation (prototype simplification)
- Visibility increases influence potential

8. Keeper System (Light Version)

At the end of each year:

- Highest influence player becomes **Keeper**

Prototype Keeper abilities:

- Boost visibility of one demo
- Suppress one demo

(No advanced fallacies or canonization yet)

Excluded Systems

The following are not part of the prototype:

- Full 7-axis tag system
- Tag permutations and degrees
- Scene Pressure system
- Canonization (Greater/Lesser)
- Dark Triad mechanics
- Advanced extraction / ownership conflicts
- Subscenes and splintering
- Audio generation system
- Multiplayer networking (can be simulated locally)

Single Round Example

1. First turn: Player selects **Gestate**
2. Action 1: Visit Library → gain *Morbid* tag
3. Action 2: Combine tag + guitar aspect → create idea
4. End Turn:
 - a. Scene updates
 - b. Wait others
5. Second turn: Player selects **Rehearse**
6. Start a new set. Give set name. Place guitar idea on a new track on the set, combine with other ideas from other actors. Give track name. Declare track composed.
7. Practice new set to improve conveyance.
8. End Turn.
9. Third Turn: Stay on **Rehearse**. Practice twice to improve conveyance. Record the tape. End Turn.
10. Fourth Turn: Select **Promote**.
11. Improve scene presence.
12. Release demo tape.
13. End Turn:
 - a. Scene updates
 - b. New Keeper based on demo success.

(Next round, the player is the Keeper and can only suppress and boost one demo per turn.)

Success Criteria

The prototype is considered successful if players can follow the example gameplay, and the scene is updated and alive based on their decisions.

3. Target Audience

Demo(n)Tapes seeks to capture the middle-aging casual gamers who recognize its underground aesthetic as its audience, the very people whom in general let out a muffled chuckle when they hear or see something darkly humorous or slightly off-kelter. This segment of society is not large by any means, but as stated in the executive summary, this is also an art project, so the creator will not live or die based on this project making it to the big leagues.

Obviously, if a gaming metalhead of any age sees a thumbnail that looks like a Darkthrone or Cannibal Corpse album cover, they are likely to click it to see what it is. They are not likely to face a price tag anytime soon.

A note on complexity: Demo(n)Tapes is designed with systemic simulations in mind, rather than as an easily approachable, content-driven management game. It seeks to purposefully consider and express topics such as ideological tension, scarcity and social power dynamics over optimization or linear progression. The many systems in place seek to establish a sense of instability instead of equilibrium.

4. Main Characters

Nullsvorn from the band “Not_Saved.SNO” - the default player character.



The Player’s alter-ego is a nameless and ambivalently gendered front-person of the snordanes black metal band “**Not_Saved.SNO**” by default. They can choose their stage name, which is by default “**Nullsvorn**”. The “. SNO” hyphen is determined from a drop-down menu, by the country of origin. Many or all these options might be locked down to their defaults, depending on where the project’s development is currently at, and the same goes for the character’s outlook, which would ideally be alterable. The band’s logo is by default as depicted below.

Not_saved has been around for five or so years. A couple of fresh high school graduates formed it around '85. It used to do thrash metal covers but nowadays seeks to carve a path of their own into musical pathways seldom trodden.



The reversed cross in the logo is a nod to other bands and their aesthetics, but all the band members agree on one thing: *for metal to stand for something, one really must do an **inversion** of some sort*. Like go against established religion or state or something. Also, music should be Trve. Whatever that means. Who knows?

Nullsvorn as the band leader (a controller; see chapter 4) has their hands full with executive decisions such as how much of an effort the band in general puts to gestating (producing material; chapter 4), rehearsals, promoting their material or leisure time. Besides this, Nullsvorn is also the lyricist and the vocalist of the band, so they contribute the voice into the end goal of the band, which is always the next demo tape. There are three other **band members** (actors; chapter 4). One plays the bass, Sithrogürd, one plays the electric guitar, Keiser, and another does the drumming, Molotov. Sithrogürd has a brother, Oystein (an agent), who is hiding the police for trying to burn their ex's house, and the ex is also in play, dating Nullsvorn (a groupie).

Each character who is directly participating in the demo recording process has **aspects** and **tags**. **Aspects** measure the way they participate – Nullsvorn's aspects are *fry-vocals* and *lyricism*. The band itself can also hold aspects: *corpse paint* and *true snordenmarkians*. Sithrogürd has *bass* and *arsonist*. Keiser has *guitar* aspect, and Molotov has both the *drummer* and *keyboard* aspects.

Nullsvorn's **Instinctual Axis** is Transgression vs Sanctification, and they lean towards the Sacred tag on that axis. This means that they are a spiritual person by nature, attuned to discussions about faith and such. Each character has one "home axis" that cannot be changed, but the leaning can change to one of three postures (lean tag, lean anti-tag and neutral). By leaning into the Sacred tag, Nullsvorn can always access its permutations and come out as authentic and serious but dealing with Profanity causes them stress.

Nullsvorn holds the following tag permutations at the beginning of the game: reverent (pagan), spiteful, embracing (groupie). Most of the people Nullsvorn associates with are spiteful, negative people, so the "spiteful tag" is **a resonance tag** – one that sticks with the character and is tied to their overall circumstances in life. The spitefulness is the 1st degree permutation of the malevolence tag. They are also feeling infatuated ("embracing" a 2nd degree permutation of the warm tag), which is **a mood tag** that can be resolved through simple actions. Mood changes faster than resonance. Finally, the reverent tag (a 1st degree permutation of the sacred tag) is **a conviction tag**. The conviction tag is always tied to the instinctual axis defined earlier, and it contains the tag Nullsvorn is leaning into on that axis. If they were neutral, that slot would be empty.

Containing Sacred, It means Nullsvorn leads a pagan lifestyle and can always opt to provide a pagan tag to any piece of music they are involved with. If Nullsvorn is somehow forced to commit actions that are against their conviction tag, their mood is likely to shift to a negative one.

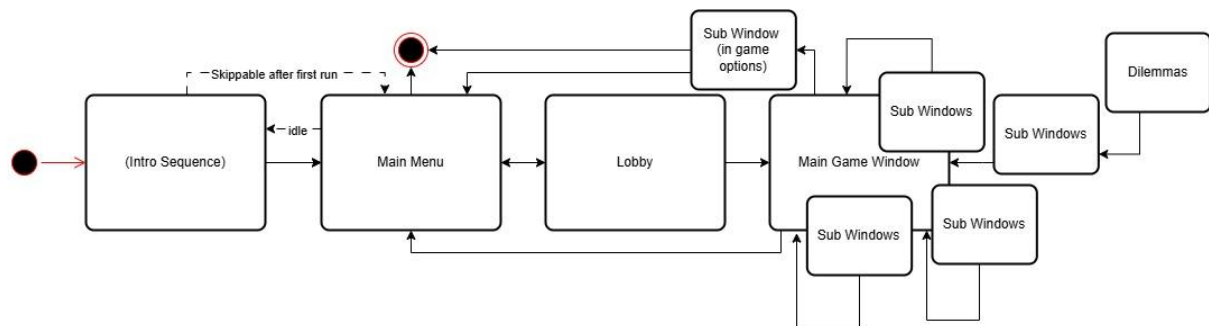
If Nullsvorn spends an action gestating in the library, they can acquire basically any tag as a low degree permutation, because they can spend an effort studying whatever topic they want, and become inspired by it. Nullsvorn can also go to a church and acquire the local resonance tag permutation as a transient tag, but it will disappear from their possession quickly, because it bothers them (due to the pagan tag). All actor and controller class characters have one or more transient tag slots.

As time progresses Not_Saved and the rest of the local bands will eventually come to terms what constitutes KVLT. As this concept solidifies, and the music that the scene produces is extreme in nature, the choices that these bands do in their production and promotion get more extreme. The harder they go against norms, the greater the reward inside the scene. But as the scene gets more notoriety, more outside forces will turn against it. Also, as different personalities transcend to positions of greater scene influence, the more fragmentation within the scene happens. Some participants might err on the side of personal glory, not really caring the scene itself. The game becomes increasingly more about weeding out bad people than it is about policing the sonic definition of KVLT.

In the end, the scene in Snordenmark either breaks through to the mainstream and real recording studios pick interest in their sounds, or their music gets forgotten as a footnote of history, along with the notorious few who participated in making it.

5. Main Features

5.1. UI and UX



To play the game and navigate its contents, the player has access to different windows and interfaces. In quasi-chronological order:

5.1.1. Main Menu

- a. **Start Game** (The player enters a call-sign used to make a distinction from other players; the game checks if the call-sign is in use and asks for another if it is)
 - Start as host
 - Join as client
- b. **Settings**
- c. **Exit**

5.1.2. Main game window

The basic window always features a **world map that gets updated after each turn**. The available interactions are highlighted as nodes on the map. Nodes are usually cities or other locations of significance, and clicking on one opens a list of targets, which are more specific locations (a library, a police station, a church... etc). The immersion is backed with splashes that describe actions and their outcomes. The Main Game Window is always visible, but the action at hand can produce short time clutter over it. Keeper Window (a) or Player

Window (b) is superimposed over the main window. Information window (c) is also available, regardless of player status (as keeper or regular).

Besides the world map, also a **thematic scene map** is present, depicting the composition of what is considered TRVE within KVLТ, alongside with any formed subscenes and their TRVE compositions relative to KVLТ. Different audio representations of the sound of TRVE within KVLТ is accessible by fiddling with the thematic scene map, so hovering mouse over a certain TRVE TAG (see 4.5 and 4.6) causes a loop to be played which demonstrates the circumstances they have been played in. An individual tag can be listened with a click, but all the derived tags gravitating the true tags orbit are played simultaneously in a cacophonous demonstration of what the scene in question sounds like. The scene map can also be put into geographical mode, so it demonstrates over the world map where the scene being played is relevant.

5.1.3. Keeper window

Keeper actions window (Gate Keeping and management of the Hole). Keeper actions window accesses other player's band leaders as splashes and provides actions for and against them and their recordings. Keeper actions can also control all the promotion that takes place in The Hole, which is the most powerful place of promotion in the scene.

5.1.4. Regular player window

Gestation actions window. Gestation actions produce splashes that depict areas of interest where the player has chosen to send their actor. This could be a library, a mall, a police station, anything really. The operation is resolved on the splash window, after which the game entity whose action it is has expended one action for the turn.

Rehearsal actions window depicts the bands rehearsal space via a shaky camcorder, with each band member ready to interact with the task at hand via their chosen aspect (usually an instrument, see 4.2 and 4.3). The player gets to access each actor's available tags and arrange them into tracks that first exist as ideas. In the rehearsal space, there is a 4-track recorder, which can be opened and used to create a record of the idea (process described at 4.7). There is also a shelf of VHS-cassettes, which serves as an access point to past arrangements. When a VHS tape is chosen during rehearsal actions, the UI tells if it's declared finished or not by showing a mess of hewed notes and beer bottles on a table vs. a clean table for a composed work.

Networking and promotional actions window

Networking and Promotional actions allow characters to spread the word of their recordings in the game world via placing posters and sending tapes via mail. Promotional actions can also be used to vandalize or negate other bands promotional actions that have been taken on earlier turns. Sometimes the band might even do a gig. Hiring new band members or interacting with them as independent actors also works here.

5.1.5. Information Window

Information Window contains information of the overall game state and can be used to access each player's public game progress information, alongside the representation of players auditive work, if a tape is available. By default, the information window contains local players information. The other player's information is accessible only to the degree by which their sonic output has been made public either by personal promotional action or by having produced a tape that exists on the thematic scene map. The same information is also

accessible on the thematic scene map, but one can approach tags by the logic of their ownership in the game via the information window.

5.1.6. Audio Presentation and Soundscapes

The audio presentation of the game follows two distinct principles. The first is a mellow, passive, and minimalist presence, consisting of ambient soundscapes, hyper-intimately presented characters (such as breath and stimming), and room-reflective reverbs. Regular communication between game characters is conveyed through short, emotive, Scandinavian-style gibberish. Music may be present in this layer, but it is distinctly analogue or “computer gamey” in character.

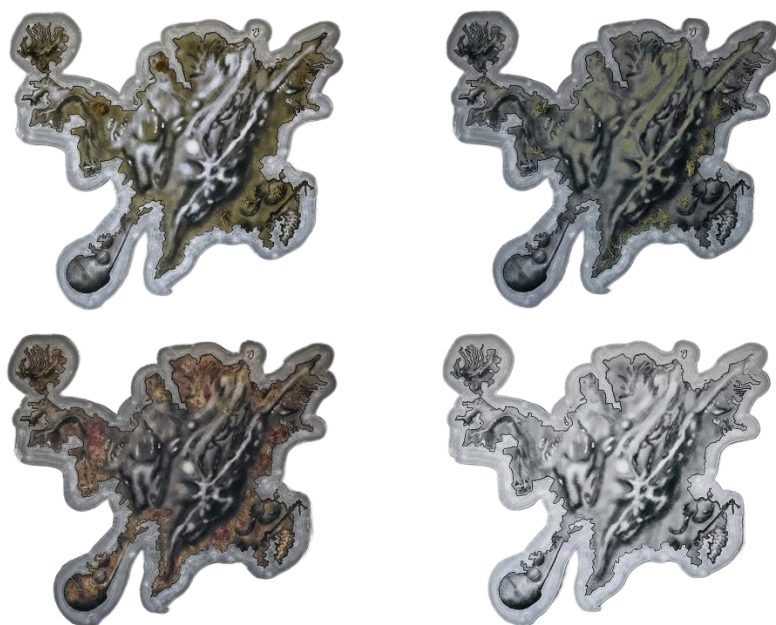
In contrast, the second principle is the active and aggressive “sound of the scene,” which is always player-originating and optional. This layer is typically accessed through interaction with the thematic scene map, allowing the player to listen to the individual or grouped sonic output of bands within the scene.

Together, these two principles establish a wide dynamic range between the player’s goals—such as producing a demo tape—and the quieter, more subdued sounds of the processes required to achieve them, including interactions with UI elements and navigation through different actions and spaces. The game is not inherently loud; instead, it communicates the concept of loudness in a stylized, almost cartoony manner.

In real-world terms, the gameplay soundscape of Demo(N)Tapes can be described as a shifting interplay between the minimalist atmosphere of dungeon synth and the experimental, raw, and harsh texture of an underground metal band’s drunken rehearsal tape, as heard through an 80s analogue recorder.

5.2 Core Gameplay Loop

A game of Demo(n)Tapes is played across a series of years (rounds), which are divided into four seasons (turns).



The changing of turns is reflected on the game map by the passage of seasons.

During each season, every collective (such as the player's band) chooses one collective action, and this action determines which character actions its members are allowed to perform. The season influences the available options within the collective action. A band that is rehearsing can only perform rehearsal-related actions; a band that is gestating can only perform gestation-related actions, for example, and a band taking promotional pictures during the winter has different options to the band that does it in summer.

Before making the seasonal decisions that requires a collective stance, a Season's Gossip interface opens, where the outcome of last season is described and actions that require reactions are provided. This quick splash interface lets players react to other people's actions with fast thumbs up, thumbs down or ignore reactions.

During their character actions, controllers and actors generate ideas through their aspects, acquire transient tags from the world through interactions, and combine their existing tags into materials that can later be used in the recording process. Some transient tags must be used quickly or they expire, and they are required for the

creation of tag-pairs, which are necessary for producing tracks that are perceived as TRVE within KVL T. Tag manifestations in the game world have degrees of effectiveness, which influence the output of each track's score, and the higher degrees require transgressing behaviour to be accessible. Besides producing tracks, the band is expected to promote their art by playing shows at underground venues. Without visibility, they are at the mercy of the Keeper. Success in the scene is measured less by musicianship and more via the notoriety of the bands output and other actions.

At the end of every season, the results of these actions update the band's creative progress, ideological profile, and influence over the scene. The culmination of their efforts materializes as demo tapes, which are shown as entities floating around an ideological map, called The Scene Map. All tapes in circulation are arranged into clusters orbiting the Scene Nexus, and clusters can have followers (called moons) of their own, depending on the way their sound is related to each other.

After every four seasons (one year), overall progress is evaluated, and the next year's Keeper is determined. The Keeper, the most influential player of last season, cannot produce new material but instead influences others from the position of authority, by allowing access to cheaper and specialised services, social and ideological manoeuvring. The Keeper's goal is to nurture their personal legacy by lifting bands that are following the Keeper's sound, instead of bands that are doing their own thing.

A band that gets on the wrong side of the Keeper must efficiently exist in the minds of the rest of the scene as the most radical and true cult example of it, up to a point in which the Keepers manoeuvring against them fails. This is accomplished by getting supported by effective networking and by producing demos so fitting to the sound demand of the scene, that the Keeper would harm themselves by ignoring them.

A release must find a way to be more radical than the last, if one is to become influential in the Scene. The further the game progresses, the more the Scene demands more radical actions. Characters who handle these actions easily lose parts of themselves and become almost addicted to their luminary state. These luminaries then, although putting forth even more outrageous music, become a threat to the Scene itself.

The loop repeats indefinitely, until an end-game event terminates the scene. An end-game action can be an outside force halting the scene's free action (because of too much notoriety), or the concept of *trve* getting somehow lost in the process. The game loop is escalatory in nature, and the players are forced to judge the notoriety of their actions against the overall health of the scene. The Keeper who is in charge when things collapse is punished for letting the game end.

5.3 Game Entity Characters, Operative Agencies, and Action Economy

Demo(n)Tapes models an underground music scene through two design-level operative layers: **Game Entities** and **Collectives**. A *Game Entity* is any meaningful object in the world that can hold tags and a membership in collective— mostly characters, locations and buildings. Characters form band collectives, locations belong to a grander area such as a city, and buildings can exist in collectives by location or function (all the post offices in the country are a functional collective, the post office at a certain city might be in the same block collective as a general store).

Game Entities have a few unifying features: They are all capable of holding tags, they can belong to multiple collectives, they can all be destroyed, damaged, fixed. They have allegiances, usually influenced by the collective memberships.

All game entities share these features:

- persistent identity (ID, name/label)
- collective memberships with active vs. passive flags
- tag container 1: resonance
- generic state container
- location or scope anchor
- information scope state
- seven domain values corresponding to the seven tag axes

Domain Values

These values represent the current state of the entity across the seven domains. They are stored on the entity, while collectives, connections, and actions act as sources that influence them.

-
- **Physical (Hostility ↔ Altruism): HP/SDC**
Hit points or structural damage capacity (SDC).
Represents the entity's physical integrity and ability to withstand or receive damage.
 - An entity without hit points or SDC is out of action, perhaps permanently
-
- **Existential (Morbid ↔ Vital): Regeneration Rate**
Vitality or will to persist.
Governs regeneration, long-term decay, and recovery of physical state.
 - An entity without regeneration rate has no means of recovery
-
- **Interpretive (Void ↔ Meaning): Motivation**
Meaning coherence.
Represents how much stable meaning or purpose the entity carries.
Influenced by collective memberships and context but not fully determined by them.
 - An entity without motivation has no capability to participate in action economy
-
- **Emotional (Cold ↔ Warm): Sentiment**
Emotional charge or degree of affective engagement.
Connections, interactions, and events act as sources that increase or decrease this value.
 - An entity without sentiment cannot understand what it is being communicated about.
-

- **Expressive (Raw ↔ Honed): Expression**
Degree of refinement or distortion of output.
Relevant for entities that produce or carry expression (e.g. characters, tracks, creative spaces).
 - An entity without expression cannot express its will
-
- **Temporal (Fast ↔ Slow): Alacrity**
Degree of preparedness versus urgency.
Reflects how controlled, planned, or rushed the entity's actions or state transitions are.
 - An entity without alacrity has no operative agency of its own or initiative
-
- **Symbolic (Profane ↔ Sacred): Symbolism**
Symbolic charge or intensity.
Represents how strongly the entity functions as a symbol within its context.
Distinct from interpretive value: symbolic concerns intensity and significance, while interpretive concerns meaning and coherence.
 - An entity without symbolic value can be interacted with in any ways desired without any kind of backlash.

5.3.1 The Game Entity Character Class

Role of a Game Entity Character operates as the current depth and level of participation in the collective (see below), rather than a fixed class. A character that is in the groupie role at the beginning of the game, for example, can advance into the actor role as their work for the band or another collective brings them to certain crossroads type events. As it stands, the character can participate in its current role at its current instance and requires the reallocation of modules to commit to another role. In a nutshell, a groupie is then a character whose controller, actor and agent modules have not been instantiated.

What follows is **the core of the game entity character class**, existing in all character instances regardless of their currently allocated role:

- current role (Controller, Actor, Agent, Groupie)
- known aspects (for example “knows how to play guitar”)
- aspect inventory (for example “has a guitar”)
- connection hooks (all characters interact with social connections on some level)
- tag container 2: mood

Not all Game Entity Characters always instantiate the full character schema. All characters share a persistent personal core, but higher-agency faculties such as conviction, transient-tag handling, instinctual alignment, and autonomous action logic are role-gated and become instantiated only when the character's participation deepens.

Characters can be roughly split into two categories with two templates. Agents are instantiated with the lesser character template, actors and controllers are instantiated with both the lesser and the greater character template. Groupies are instantiated without additional character templates, with only the character core values.

Lesser template includes:

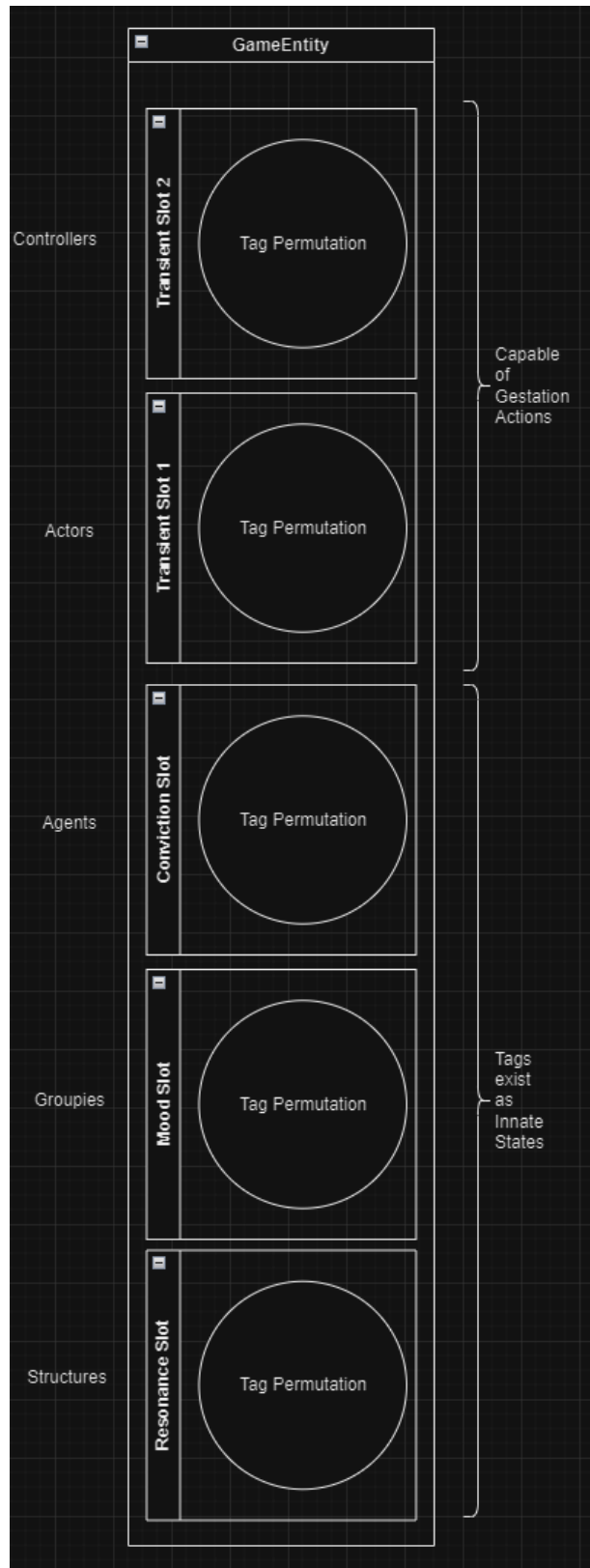
- tag container 3: conviction
- instinctual axis
- action capacity

Greater template includes:

- 2 tag containers: transient 1 and 2
- capability to have ideas and own ideas
- capability to have primary and secondary claims on novel aspects
- capability for dark triad behaviour

5.3.2 Role hierarchy (agency model)

Game-entity characters (i.e., characters depicting individuals, as opposed to locations/objects) are divided into four role categories in descending order of agency, and the degree by which they have access to tag permutations:



Controller

A high-agency character who defines a collective's direction. Band leaders are the default controller type and are what each player directly controls. A controller type character does exactly what the player wants, as they are effectively the players alter-ego in the game world. The controller term comes from the necessity of active collectives to have one of these Game-entities. A controller exists always in local scope, and they cannot do moonlighting dark triad actions. A controller has an archive of demos and a bucket of discarded tapes.

Actor

A semi-autonomous member of a collective (band members). Actors can contribute to all core creative actions, but their agency is bounded not just by the collective context chosen by the controller, but also the current layout of their tags. In real world terms, actors have things that they would prefer to do over other things, and boundaries they are not willing to cross.

Agent

A low-autonomy helper specialized in 1–2 tasks. Agents execute narrowly scoped actions and do not meaningfully participate in creative authorship unless explicitly elevated. Such a character could be for example a poet whom another character knows, who simply provides lyrics in one instance of composition.

Groupie

An attachment-like character primarily functioning as a situational modifier or a "social vector" tied to another entity or tag (e.g., an infatuation tag that manifests as an actual person). Groupies can assist or hinder specific actions depending on context and alignment. For example, a seasoned producer could provide a recording effort a bonus or penalty if the recording event takes place in a situation where the groupie is available.

5.3.3 Collectives (Revised)

A *Collective* is a group of entities that acts as a unit, most importantly **bands**, but also other “organized” groupings when needed (a venue’s staff, a record shop’s network, a local clique, even the society etc.). This distinction matters because some **collectives**, **called Active Collectives**, **choose a collective action**, while passive collectives instead serve as a backdrop for measuring other collectives’ or game entities actions. For example, the music scene this game depicts, an active collective, is built over a cultural opposition against the Society, usually a passive collective.

Collectives are a foundational organizational structure for game entities. At their simplest form, they are passive groupings that unify suitable entities under a shared context, purpose, or allegiance. A collective can reflect the state of its members: it may “suffer” when its members suffer, and it may cease to function if its membership collapses or if other critical conditions are met. Their most important task is to communicate allegiance and contextual belonging within the simulation.

A game entity may belong to multiple passive collectives simultaneously. Membership in such collectives is considered **passive** by default and does not directly restrict the entity’s available actions, but may influence outcomes, tag availability, or interaction context.

Active and Passive Collectives

All Collectives share the following traits:

- A list of its Game Entity type members.
- A boolean of whether they are active.
- An alignment matrix for the 7 tag axes (each has a value ranging from -5.0f to 5.0f).

Collectives exist in two primary modes:

Passive Collectives

- Do not require a controller to exist.
- Serve as semantic, social, or institutional backdrops.
- Provide tags, aspects, and contextual modifiers.
- May become active under specific conditions.

Active Collectives

- Require a Controller-type entity to function.
- Without a controller, their agency remains dormant.
- When active, they define a **collective stance**, which constrains and enables the actions of their members during a season.
- Membership in an active collective can be:
 - **Active**, locking the entity into the collective's action set.
 - **Passive**, granting only indirect benefits (e.g., influence gain, shared aspects).

A game entity may have only **one active membership** in an active collective at a time.

Collectives as Semantic Containers

Beyond membership, collectives act as **semantic containers** within the simulation. Each collective may hold:

- **Aspect Sets** (e.g., canonized aspects, novelty aspect pools)
- **Tag Permutation Sets** (ideological composition)
- **Eligibility Rulesets** (defining what is valid within that collective's context)
- **Institutional Memory** (persistent structural state)

These sets are critical for systems such as:

- novelty
 - TRVE validation
 - legitimacy evaluation
 - scene evolution
-

Band and KVL T Collectives

The most common active collective is the **band**, which operates through seasonal stances (gestation, rehearsal, promotion).

Another key active collective is **KVL T**, controlled by the Keeper via The Hole structure. When a Keeper is chosen at the end of a round:

- Their membership in their band becomes **passive**
- Their membership in the Hole becomes **active**
- Their band collective becomes dormant (effectively passive)

This transition replaces band-level actions with **Keeper actions**, shifting the player's role from participant to institutional actor.

KVLT as a Collective

KVLT is modelled as a special active collective representing the current state of the scene itself. It is always controlled by the current Keeper through the Hole.

KVLT operates on two layers:

1. Canon Layer (Stable, Institutional)

- Updated only through **Greater Canonization events**
- Contains:
 - canonized aspects
 - canonized tag permutations
 - structural definitions of what is considered legitimate within the scene
- Forms the long-term identity of the scene

2. Dynamic Scene Pressure Layer (Fluid, Reactive)

- Continuously influenced by the Gravity of active, non-canonized clusters
- Represents the current directional “pull” of the scene
- Does not immediately alter canon, but affects:
 - perceived alignment
 - temporary legitimacy
 - ongoing competition between ideas

KVLT therefore acts both as:

- a **stable institutional authority** (through canon)
 - a **reactive field of influence** (through dynamic pressure)
-

Society as a Collective

Society is modelled as a large-scale passive collective with a dormant controller entity known as **The Man**.

Society contains:

- the **dominant aspect set** of the world (institutions, norms, structures)
- tag permutations considered socially legitimate or normative
- ideological structures such as organized religion and state authority

KVLT is defined in opposition to Society. The re-sacralising tag-pair system relies on this relationship: the submissive component of a tag-pair must correspond to a value upheld by Society.

All characters belong to Society as passive members. This membership:

- establishes them as legal entities within the world
- exposes them to consequences when Society becomes active

When notoriety reaches a sufficient threshold:

- Society transitions toward an active state
 - The Man mobilizes institutional pressure against the scene
 - This escalation drives the simulation toward end-game conditions
-

Design Implication

Collectives are not only groupings of entities but **competing semantic systems**. KVLТ and Society form the primary ideological opposition:

- **KVLТ** defines what is becoming legitimate within the scene
- **Society** defines what must be opposed for legitimacy to emerge

All major systems—tags, TRVE, novelty, influence—operate within this tension.

5.3.4 Collective actions → character actions (season structure)

Each season, every player selects **one of the collective action stances** for their band collective (e.g., gestate, rehearse, promote). This enables the player an access to a new menu of **character actions** based on that stance. In practice, the player chooses the band's seasonal intent first and then spends character actions within that constraint.

The core idea is that *scene participation requires trade-offs*: if the band is rehearsing, it cannot simultaneously do full gestation exploration at the same depth; if it is promoting, it is not maximizing rehearsal improvements. All the chosen actions, including the choice of stance, are reversable until end turn button is pressed.

If the player is the Keeper, they do not select a stance as the Keeper is technically the part-time controller of KVL T and has access to one stance, which is the Keeper stance. Instead, they just commit to Keeper actions, which are management actions that directly influence the immediate scene around the record shop. As a Keeper, that player is also viable to do ad hoc decisions between turns, when conflicting interests require resolving.

5.3.5 Action economy (2:3 rule) and resolution overview

Characters typically perform **two actions for free** each season. A **third action** can be taken at a cost (the **2:3 rule**), introducing fatigue and risk. Overextending is a meaningful choice: it may accelerate creative progress or networking, but it increases the likelihood of negative side-effects in the current or following season.

All players declare actions **asynchronously** without knowing others' choices. At end-of-turn, actions resolve together; shared targets are treated as "coinciding" within the season's fiction. The current Keeper may interact with some outcomes during the end-of-turn phase (supporting, suppressing, reframing, or otherwise intervening). Local actions are resolved on the local client if there is no window for interaction between players. Conflicts between players are resolved on the Keeper client, because the Keeper has a say on all such dilemmas. When the end of turn is activated locally, the current choices are locked in, and all empty choices are considered "rest" actions. The end of turn is automatically triggered, when a suitable time has been spent on the turn window (length determined in testing).

A conflict occurs when two or more players commit to an action that cannot be co-operated with and has mutually exclusive outcomes and happens simultaneously – at the same time in season (first actions are early, second actions late and third actions even later). Early actions can defeat late and later actions, late actions only later actions. Moonlighting actions (see Dark Triad) win all conflicts, because they are opportunistic and ruthless, except when executed by a Rat (see Dark Triad; The Means, travel & other expenses), who always loses. Other useful conflict resolution metrics are if one party operates on a local scope, and another at a removed scope: Local beats Removed.

Three stages of network synchronization occur during end-of-turn resolution:

1. First, a lightweight synchronization step determines shared and conflicting targets across players. (gated by the time limit of the turn or when all players have ended their turn)
2. If conflicts are detected, a second stage transmits full action data to the Keeper client, where authoritative resolution is performed. (Gated by the Keeper's time limit, handled as a quick dilemma. Neutral stance by default when viable, resolve gridlocks with rng when all else fails.)
3. Finally, resolved outcomes are applied locally and then propagated to the host, who distributes the updated state to all clients.

Resolution Scope: Local vs Removed

Resolution scope defines the **precision and fidelity with which actions are executed and resolved**, not merely who performs them.

The game operates through a single player perspective: the player's controller character. All actions are interpreted through this perspective, but not all actions are resolved with the same level of detail.

Local scope represents the immediate environment of the controller character. Actions in local scope are defined by precise intent, specific targets, and constrained conditions. They are resolved with high fidelity and are described as events directly witnessed by the player. In later stages of development, local scope actions are intended to support more detailed, "game-like" simulation.

Removed scope represents actions performed outside the controller's immediate environment. These actions are defined by generalized intent and category-level targets. They are resolved through abstract systems with reduced precision, introducing variability in both outcome and interpretation. Removed scope actions are described from a distance and reflect indirect knowledge.

At the current stage of implementation, both local and removed scope actions are resolved using the same abstract system. However, the distinction between scopes remains a design-level constraint. Local scope actions are provided with higher specificity and tighter outcome bounds, while removed scope actions retain broader variance and uncertainty.

Control and Delegation

The controller character is the only entity directly operated by the player and always acts within local scope. The controller's current location defines what constitutes local scope.

Other characters (actors and agents) operate through delegation. When they act outside the controller's local scope, their actions are resolved at removed scope. If they operate within the controller's local scope, their actions are treated as local and resolved with higher fidelity, even if not directly controlled.

Groupies do not independently perform actions.

Stance Interaction

Resolution scope is especially relevant during **gestation** and **promotion** stances, where outcomes depend heavily on contextual awareness and precision of execution.

If a controller requires a specific outcome, they must either:

- perform the action themselves, or
- be physically present to ensure local scope resolution

Delegated actions at removed scope cannot guarantee exact outcomes.

Rehearsal Exception (Hermetic Locality)

Rehearsal actions are hermetically sealed from outside influence and always resolve within local scope.

The following entities exist strictly within local scope:

- track construction
- rehearsal VHS tape objects

- unreleased demo materials

The **master demo** is a local entity. All demo tapes in circulation are derived from it.

Only local scope can produce:

- the master recording
- the first dub of a demo tape

A **dub** represents a batch of copies. The number associated with a dub indicates its generational distance from the master, reflecting how far removed it is from the original source.

Design Implication

If precision matters, presence matters.

Local scope provides control and specificity.

Removed scope provides reach but introduces uncertainty.

Collective Stances and Stance Actions

Gestation Stance

In a gestation stance, a band collective interacts with the world in search of inspiration, or engages in other types of preparation, such as gathering of stage props. Controllers interact with the game world as per their own desires, actors try their best to do what is expected on them, agents beeline to their targets and groupies just tag along with whomever they have been assigned to. All gestation actions procure tags from game entities or add new aspects to the band collective's reservoir.

Notice that one can extract an intact idea from somebody else's demo, and the extracted idea will be considered "free" if the gestate action beats the tag's conveyance score. Failing to do so, the action extracts the idea with the signature of its creator.

local	removed
Acquire specific tag in reach.	Acquire a tag or its association (uses Means).

Acquire a specific aspect in reach.	Pull an aspect from a set of aspects (uses Means).
Add a tag permutation into an aspect to form an idea.	
Rip idea from demo (beat conveyance). Anti-tag dormant; ownership lingers, risking later conflict.	
Scry a demo tape to reveal its precise information.	

In Gestation Stance, only News that happen locally are updated to experienced scope, unless a band member is active in the area with the event taking place (resolution scope is “removed state” with a matching location to the event).

Rehearsal Stance

The Rehearsal process with its composing and recording actions are described in detail later, at sub-chapter 4.8: Track Constructing and Recording. The rehearsal stance does not allow individual actions, so the gameplay does not simulate individual takes for example. Instead, the collective works as a single entity.

- Composition actions are made to arrange the formed ideas into suitable combinations, “songs”. These songs are represented by VHS tapes. The ideal form of the song lives separately from a demo tape, and a live gig taps into the version held by VHS tape, instead of the one in circulation. A single composition action can form multiple tracks. A composition action is usually finished after all tags and ideas for that action are expended.
- A few songs can be recorded into cassettes, after which they become an instance that can be spread via networks in promotion actions, they interact with the scene, produce influence for the band and stop eroding due to forgetfulness.
- A band in rehearsal stance only acquires News in the Acquaintance scope, because the whole collective is so deeply concentrating on the work.

Promotion actions build up momentary scene presence over the default value based on the connectedness of the band, accomplished via circulating cassettes, posturing and direct actions that align with the band's releases.

- A double down posturing action (“posing”) can be used to distance or align one's collective to something that has happened within last four turns (the reaction targets are all existing **Narrative Aspects or their happenings** that are considered “fresh” and haven't been posed to by the party in question already). This can improve or reduce the target instances connections and thus their scene presence, but the connections work both ways. This action is taken on an already established reaction, which is resolved reflexively at the start of turn (see stance neutral actions).
- **TRVE activation action.** Unless the trve tags are embedded in a suitable narrative aspect (which bypasses the following requirement), the TRVE value is dormant – just words on paper for example. This activation action is direct communication with the scene through action. Up to a certain degree of TRVE, it can be a simple gig with provocative stage props, but further down the line the action is highly transgressive and likely illegal.
 - The action's degree of transgression determines the TRVE degree of the tag being activated, with the actual tag permutation's degree as the maximum possible value.
 - A track can be activated on a lesser degree than it holds, but going over the degree brings diminishing returns.
 - A track can have one promotional action per collective per turn. A degree can be reactivated or improved on each turn.
 - Each track of TRVE requires a different activation action, but all trve tags are on one track are activated with a single action.
 - If the track is activated by both a narrative aspect and the activation action, the TRVE degree is calculated using the roof of the tag-pair instead of the floor.
 - The target track can be any track in Scene Space, not just one's own. Somebody else can commit to an inspired action dedicated to the track.

Promoting the same tag counts as collaboration, and the degrees can stack up to the maximum of double the regular max degree.

- Activating the TRVE tags of a track also activates the novelty modifier. If a novel track is in play with dormant tags, it is ignored on all accounts.
- Taking the promotion stance can often mean getting up to date on things that would otherwise get missed in other stances, since it relies so heavily on connections. The News are automatically updated to analytic scope.

Keeper Stance

- All the Keeper actions balance between exploiting the position and grooming the scene.
 - Whereas others acquire influence from their demo tapes and their primary releases paving way for them advancing towards influential position within KVL T, a Keeper has already crossed that threshold. Keeper receives influence normally from secondary and beyond clusters, but the primary cluster is on its way to become canonized. **Instead of receiving influence from primary cluster, the Keeper gets Pull.**
 - **Kiss the ring.** A Keeper has Scene Presence 1, which is a huge asset. The caveat is that they have just recently released their last tape and cannot produce a new one for as long as they are a Keeper. But they can release other people's tapes, which is arguably one of their most powerful tools. If a band is closely associated with the Keeper (orbiting one of their clusters; not the primary one getting canonized), they can "Kiss the ring" and re-release at SP 1. This levies **a Keeper tax** on the record, based on the local orbital influence of the record (the less the influence, the greater the tax). Kissing the ring is possible at any time the band is in promotion stance and can be used as an option of a demo release if it would end up orbiting a secondary (or further) Keeper cluster, or optionally it can target an already released demo, in which case it is released as a rogue moon.

- The Keeper has access to three manoeuvres called The Fallacies, once per turn. The effect of each fallacy persists for 4 turns, and having all of them levied against a single band is devastating for their influence:
 - **No True Scotsman (NTS).** Point at a specific non canon tag permutation at a cluster of releases. Push against all instances of that tag relative to KVLT with extra ferocity (add Keeper Pull).
 - **Guilt by Association (GBA).** Reassign a more suitable home for a specific record, comparing it to another existing scene. Push against this individual record, derived on its success in that other scene and Keeper Pull.
 - **Ad Hominem (ADH).** Target a specific controller and use their character traits for leverage against them. Suitable points of criticism are Dark Triad traits, conformism, novelty etc...
- Keeper's voice is considered twice the value of other players when resolving **beefs**, plus it breaks ties.

If the game ends with either variation of scene collapse while the player is the Keeper, they receive a penalty to the final score for being the person who dropped the ball. In the unlikely instance that the game ends with the scene overpowering society, or forcing a cultural upheaval, the last Keeper should have a bonus to the last score instead.

Stance neutral actions

Some actions are not tied to a specific stance but become available in more than one stance. Other actions are factored into the actual actions taken in the turn. For example, travelling to a destination is important in both gestation and promotional

actions. Hence if a gestation action takes place far, its travel cost is factored into play. In this game, car-pooling is a thing.

There are also collective interactions that do not interact with the action economy, such as interacting with The Scene Map, The Hole or the Band to kick a person off the band. These things happen outside of time and the costs they yield are just as immediate as the actions themselves.

Finally, there are stance neutral actions that are always available, that cost one or more actions. Such actions are move, change band camp, lay low and hide. Actors might find themselves in situations where they commit to these actions without asking or might refuse to do so when asked if they don't see the point in it.

- Instinctual Axis adjustment (Controllers, Actors): Lean into or out of current conviction on instinctual axis (+1 or -1 to degree, max 2). If the degree drops to 0, conviction tag is lost.
- Rest action is used to recover means or fix a negative state. Some negative states require two rest actions (an entire round).
- Move (Controller) means the character changes to another residence if such is available... this takes one regular action and costs one Means for the controller. The entire collective's base of operations is moved.
- Lay low takes one regular action but costs 2 Means. It provides safety for the character doing it, when a 3rd party is searching for them, allowing them also to have a degree of activity among the rest of the collective.
- Hide takes an entire turn and puts the character beyond their Means. Making the character in question unavailable but very safe. Two consecutive hide actions push the character to the Rat state, where all Dark Triad actions are considered moonlighting.
- Reacting to turn gossip with a ternary reaction {-, 0, +}.

Switchless actions

If a band collective remains in the same posture for more than one turn, the collective gets a switchless action benefit, which is a benefit that varies depending on the posture. Starting from the second turn in that posture, **Gestate posture** yields relaxed benefit, **Rehearsal posture** bypasses forgetfulness rule for lack of rehearsing, **Promotion posture** bypasses the Cold Wind of Snordenmark-rule for that turn.

- **Relaxed:** If a character is in relaxed state, they acquire a duplicate transient tag slot, including the permutation that resides in the original slot if it's occupied. This means they can share the duplicate with another member of the band. Relaxed state remains for one turn after leaving gestation stance.
- **Forgetfulness:** Each turn that the band doesn't start in rehearse position, all their VHS conveyances drop. Conveyance decay mod: 0.95 per turn.
- **Cold Wind of Snordenmark:** Each turn spent outside of Promotion posture the Scene Presence value drops. Cold Wind mod: 0.85 per turn.

5.4 Aspects, Ideas and Conveyance

An aspect is any trait an entity possesses that can host a tag to form an idea. For example, a guitar riff is an idea of the guitar aspect that has a tag conveying the author's intent. A collective can also hold an aspect, such as the collective society's hold on Christianity as a state religion. Collectives keep aspects in another way than characters: Collectives use aspects to define what is normative, characters interact with the game world through their aspects.

An aspect does not do much by itself, but it can be instantiated into an idea, and an idea can (and must) host a tag (see below). Each character has a capacity to indefinitely hold a set number of ideas, but the idea must be built again once expended. A collective can also keep some ideas, and the association with those ideas is permanent and always accessible to the members of the collective (although nothing forces these aspects to be put on play turn to turn).

Besides being the natural path for tag permutations to come to play, using aspects can cause different kinds of changes on character actions, depending on how KVLTLT prefers things to be handled. If corpse paint is something desirable in what is considered TRVE, then it yields a bonus for the band utilizing it. If the bagpipe aspect

is considered something unheard of in KVLTL, it might carry a penalty, unless it manages to do the exact opposite and the novelty itself gives it a bonus instead (see 4.7: **novelty**).

Aspects are also defined by **an item component** which is the physical manifestation of the aspect, or a focal point of the aspect if it requires one. A guitar is needed to play a guitar riff, for example. Aspects can also model events, such as “I wrote this song in Hawaii”, in which case the item component could be a post card.

Some significant gameplay events spawn a special case of aspect called **narrative aspect**. The narrative aspect doesn’t really have an item component, but a past event component called **happening**. A narrative aspect’s happening could for example be “the breaking and entering action targeting a store” on turn 3 of round 5. This aspect can be played inside an idea to signal the rest of the scene that the band was somehow involved in it. Narrative aspects with their happenings are very strong influence gainers, because the happening activates the accompanied tag-pair out of the box. This means that the band doesn’t have to separately activate a track’s TRVEness via a performance.

A trait called **conveyance** is attached to the idea, which stands for the level of clarity at which the idea can be presented. This is as close as we get to “musicianship” or “technical skill value” in this game. It’s a normalized floating-point number that quite simply tells us how well the idea comes through on the recording. The conveyance does two main things:

- it reads as a percentage of how much of the connected permutation’s degree is presentable. An idea that hosts a 2nd degree permutation that is recorded at conveyance score of 0.7 reads as 2nd degree, but conveyance score of 0.5 reads as 1st degree. Use regular rounding rules.
- it serves as a buffer against extraction attempts by other bands – if your track conveyance sucks, it’s easy to steal your idea and claim it original (because nobody could make any sense of your own version). If the extraction action fails to beat your conveyance, it extracts as “your” idea. Otherwise, it extracts as a generic idea.

- it can also mask a narrative aspect's happening if left weak (low) on purpose. If there is a transgression involved in the narrative aspect, the party investigating that incidence will test against the tracks conveyance if they hear it.

When a demo tape is replicated, the conveyance score of the copy take a hit based on its **generation**, so its impact diminishes the wider the circulation it gets.

Each Aspect also has **novelty**, which is a modifier based on how approved or expected the aspect is in KVL T. Sometimes, aspects have primary and secondary claims, but only if they were novel once (within the game session). Without the specific primary or secondary claims, aspects are claimed collectively. This is discussed later in the manuscript (see 4.7.2: Cultural Modifiers and Reception: novelty).

An idea is the combination of an aspect with a tag or a tag-pair. It is modular both within the track structure and outside of it: it can be cloned to give the track more length, and it can be extracted and used in another context. If the aspect in the idea carries novelty, the idea is novel. If 1/3 or more of the ideas in a track are novel, the track is a novel track. A novel track must be TRVE and active, or it is ignored by KVL T.

5.5 Emotional & Ideological systems

5.5.1 Tags, types of tags, tag axis, instinctual axis

Tag	Anti-Tag	Axis	First Triad Affinity
Profane	Sacred	Transgression vs Sanctification	Psychopathy
Cold	Warm	Emotional Distance vs Immediacy	Narcissism
Raw	Honed	Expression vs Refinement	Narcissism
Fast	Slow	Urgency vs Deliberation	Psychopathy
Malevolent	Benevolent	Hostility vs Altruism	Narcissism
Morbid	Vital	Death Fixation vs Life Force	Psychopathy
Void	Meaning	Nihilism vs Purpose	Machiavellism

Tags are the single most important thing in the whole game because tracks are arrangements of ideas, which are tags served via aspects. Tags stand in relation with other tags, so a single tag has a so-called anti-tag, and three tags that are considered adjacent. For example, morbid anti-tag is vital, and it has an association cold, slow and void tags. Vital, in turn, has an association with warm, fast and benevolence. A person cannot hold both a tag and its anti-tag at the end of the turn following the one they acquired the anti-tag.

Tag	Adjacencies
Profane	Malevolent, Raw, Void
Cold	Void, Morbid, Slow
Raw	Profane, Fast, Malevolent
Fast	Raw, Malevolent, Vital
Malevolent	Profane, Raw, Fast
Morbid	Cold, Slow, Void
Void	Cold, Morbid, Profane

Tag	Adjacencies
Sacred	Meaning, Slow, Honed
Warm	Vital, Benevolent, Honed
Honed	Sacred, Meaning, Warm
Slow	Sacred, Cold, Morbid
Benevolent	Warm, Vital, Meaning
Vital	Warm, Fast, Benevolent
Meaning	Sacred, Benevolent, Honed

Each game entity has a **resonance tag**, which defines its nature in one word. A seedy back alley is profane, an old folk's home is slow, a sporting event is vital etc. Actual characters (Controllers, Actors, Agents and Groupies) have **mood tags**. Which is by

default one of their resonant tag adjacencies. Somebody emerges from a seedy back alley, whose mood is either malevolent, raw or void. That's just by default; mood tags are very reactive and are influenced by events a lot. Finally, there is also the **conviction tag** which is tied to a character's **instinctual axis** alignment and leaning. If a person is apolitical or otherwise disinterested in pushing their views, they can have a neutral stance, and the conviction slot is empty. Besides that, they can lean into either polarity of that axis simply by "walking the path" – doing actions that align with the tag.

Besides the three types of tags characters can possess (resonance, mood, conviction), controllers and actors can also have one or more transient tags, which are basically tags they have acquired from somewhere else and are carrying but don't subscribe to themselves. A transient tag slot carries the latest tag that was acquired, unless the tag conflicts with the character's other tags, in which case it must be played within one turn before it gets nullified.

Every game entity object carries a permutation of at least one tag (resonance tag) which means that every such object in the game can be interacted with to reach for that tag. Tags can be found from other sources, too, such as in-season tags that are naturally provided by the current turn (autumn tags can be morbid, winter tags are usually cold, for example).

Resonance tags in a character's control can be used limitlessly without exhausting them. Using a common resonance tag will, however, suffer the penalty of **resonant saturation**, which yields diminutive results on tag permutations that are the bread and butter of KVL T.

Mood tags can only be used twice per turn. If tried to access more, or if being accessed while stressed, the mood tag is going to become a "**simulacrum**" which means it doesn't carry the actual emotional energy but goes through the motions only. As an idea, it has a diminished value (active value of -2 the original).

A character's mood tags are always simulacrum, if a "mood killer" is in play. Mood killer is an idea in the current set that carries the character's mood anti-tag permutation at equal or greater degree.

A conviction tag can be accessed any number of times per turn, but a third time it is used in the same record counts as **proselytizing**, which has a risk of behaving like a simulacra or cause scene splintering.

Each tag-axis also hosts its local type of action, as per the following table.

Axis	Domain Value	Positive	Negative
Transgression vs Sanctification	Symbolic	Sanctify	Transgress
Emotional Distance vs Immediacy	Emotional	Engage	Detach
Expression vs Refinement	Expressive	Refine	Distort
Urgency vs Deliberation	Temporal	Deliberate	Rush
Hostility vs Altruism	Physical	Preserve	Harm
Death Fixation vs Life Force	Existential	Sustain	Decay
Nihilism vs Purpose	Interpretive	Assign	Negate

In the table, the domain value specifies a target of the action, and the positive and negative column specifies whether the action reinforces or degrades to the domain value. Every game entity has a relationship with each domain, because each game entity has a resonance tag.

5.5.2 Tag permutations, degrees, simulacra, the Dark Triad

Tag permutations are the actual, concrete form in which the tag manifests in the game. Permutations themselves have further determination principles. For example, the tag Sacred, must manifest in a permutation such as “reverent”. What Nullsvorn claims is the actual permutation (tag with a degree), and the “reverent” part is a specific type of tag being channelled at level 0 (see the table).

Tag permutations have degrees, or active values from 0 to 3, which basically stands for how strongly the permutation represents the tag. For example, “Profane” has four degrees: irreverent (0), defiant (1), desecrating (2) and sacrilegious (3).

The degree of the tag permutation can be encountered in the game world as it stands (2 is rare, 3 is almost unheard off and there might be police tape involved). Notice that the 0 degree represents an almost nominal stance that has no skin in the game. Further notice that 2 and beyond defines the entity that encapsulates it – a person who is “desecrating” (degree 2) is worlds apart from a person who is simply “defiant” (degree 1).

Simulacrum

Certain situations involving the 2:3 action economy rule create tag permutations called simulacra. A simulacrum is a Tag permutation that has two degrees, performative and actual. Performative value is the degree that it suggests, and actual value is the value currently in play. Active value of a simulacrum is the performative value -2. Specific in-game actions can be done to change mood originating simulacrum into a regular tag and regain performative value at its true state.

Conviction Tag Behaviour

Conviction tags can end up as simulacra, if the tags are too easily received within the scene. Such a situation is called **ideological saturation**. Ideological saturation happens when the tag permutation originating 3 or more times in one instance from a

conviction tag has a positive or neutral scene drift (D). When such is not the case, the effect is called **ideological emergence**. When the tag permutation is barely tolerated or on its way out (negative or almost neutral negative D), it can entice some people to follow it out of the TRVE KVL T. A proselytizing release that goes through a Greater Canonization will have a specific impact on the tag(s) it promotes. A proselytizing release that goes through a Lesser Canonization can capture the entire local system and form a splinter scene with them outside or inside the nexus determined scene space.

A character who carries a 3rd degree tag of any type around for over an entire turn is considered a member of “the Dark Triad”. A player can choose to de-escalate their controller character’s mental outlook before stepping into it, in which case the tag turns into a Simulacrum instead. This happens only if the character is not already “a member”. Other characters are likely to defend their own psyche via elaborate personality simulating mechanisms, which are not within the scope of the current game version.

Tag	Degree 0	Degree 1	Degree 2	Degree 3
Profane	Irreverent	Defiant	Desecrating	Sacrilegious
Cold	Distant	Aloof	Bitter	Glacial
Raw	Rough	Unpolished	Primitive	Brutal
Fast	Urgent	Driving	Frenetic	Blistering
Malevolent	Irritable	Spiteful	Vindictive	Malicious
Morbid	Gloomy	Macabre	Funereal	Sepulchral
Void	Hollow	Nihilistic	Bleak	Abyssal

Tag	Degree 0	Degree 1	Degree 2	Degree 3
Sacred	Reverent	Devout	Consecrated	Sanctified
Warm	Familial	Welcoming	Embracing	Fervent
Honed	Polished	Refined	Precise	Masterful
Slow	Measured	Heavy	Dragging	Monolithic
Benevolent	Kind	Generous	Protective	Compassionate
Vital	Lively	Energetic	Thriving	Exuberant
Meaning	Purposeful	Devoted	Zealous	Transcendent

Dark Triad is a set of traits: Machiavellism, Narcissism and Psychopathy. A character who has Dark Triad traits must play their 3rd degree trait every turn or gain stressed as if they had done 3 actions. This basically creates a reversal of the 2:3 rule, where the character must do one extreme action every turn. They cannot do 3 regular actions.

- Machiavellism (wants to be in rehearsal stance):

- Force another band members conviction anti-tag (any degree available) to play by acquiring it and using it in an idea. If none of the band members has a stance tag axis and thus no conviction, goes for mood anti-tag. If the idea is abandoned, the Machiavellian gets stressed.
- Narcissism (wants to be in a gestate stance):
 - Claim street credibility from another character's action by cloning it as a special narrative aspect during gestate action and forcing it into the band's set. Leads likely to a beef. If the suggestion gets abandoned, gets stressed. The special narrative aspect houses a simulacrum as a submissive tag by default.
- Psychopathy (wants to be in a promotion stance):
 - Tries to take an activation action in promotion stance at the highest available extremity, directed at own band collective's output. If no such thing is available, will try to do the same action to somebody else's tag-pair. If there is an intervention, gets stressed.

This automatic action is called **moonlighting** when it happens outside of the regular collective action paradigm. If the character is in gestate stance but is required to commit cloak and dagger on a band member via a rehearse action, they will do so in secret. If they are already in rehearsal stance, they automatically suggest an action that would provide the desired result. If the action is not permitted, their third action is declared in secret with the player getting feedback only as "clandestine action decided". If the player overwrites this by forcing a third regular action on the character, they become stressed as usual.

A character will always try a regular Dark Triad action if available, before moonlighting. Hence, having more than one of the traits is better, since it raises transparency. Gathering the whole set allows the character to always automatically engage from within the band's collective stance. Controller characters cannot moonlight and must always resolve their "urge" from the stance available. Failing to do so causes stress.

A character who has **The Rat** trait will automatically commit their 3rd action as one of the dark triad operations, to resolve the trait. They will resume normalcy the next turn. A character who is already in possession of a Dark Triad trait, cannot become a Rat,

as they are one always by default. While the character is a rat, they are immune to other stress effects, but the turn spent as a rat doesn't resolve any underlying stress conditions. Because of the way Rats are made, the underlying condition "Beyond Means" persists to the following turn unresolved, even if the character is no longer a rat.

Dark Triad Traits can be used as a target for the **Ad Hominem** Keeper manoeuvre. Dark Triad Traits belong to the analysed information scope, however, so they must be intimately known (such as a band member), or their acts must have been witnessed in overtly clear manner (three non-moonlighted actions).

5.5.3 Tag-Pairs and genre specific systems

Transient tags are used to create tag-pairs, which are special combinations of tags required to meet certain criteria in the creation of a record. To make a record that feels genuinely "blackened" (or TRVE), there must be a so-called **re-sacralising tag-pair** present in the record. Tag must be paired with its anti-tag, and the anti-tag must be held in value by the Society (represented by a collective type object in the game, which is used to specify the standards and norms of the game world, against which KVLTL carries on its rebellion). Furthermore, A re-sacralising tag-pair contributes to TRVE (see later) **only if it is instantiated in an idea that is fully gestated by the acting collective, not extracted from an already existent track via homage or theft, because the extracted tag-pair's anti-tag component is dormant by default.**

A Tag-pair cannot conceptually exist outside of an idea, so it requires the aspect component to host both relevant permutations.

So, to sum the process of building a re-sacralising tag-pair: Nullsvorn has the aspect lyricist, which allows them to create an idea that hosts a tag or a tag-pair. They can acquire the organized religion tag as a transient, and immediately (within a turn) place it inside a lyrical idea (so they do not have to carry it around as a transient). They attach the pagan tag into the same idea, so the pagan-organized religion tag pair is hosted safely inside the idea.

Nullsvorn can write lyrics about paganism all day long, but they must actively mock organized religion by building a pagan – organized religion tag-pair to their lyrics. The act of engaging with the subject matter is disturbing and builds into a visceral reaction on the record, which the listener can hear. The outcome is “serious”, not just a surface act. So, a re-sacralising tag-pair is made of tag and its anti-tag, the latter which evaporates quickly unless it is pinned down somehow.

5.6 Legitimacy, Influence, and Scene Dynamics

The TRVE/trve system models authenticity as a contested and dynamic property that emerges from creative tension, repetition, institutional influence, and social reaction. In Demo(n)Tapes, it is not enough for a release to merely sound appropriate to the scene. The game distinguishes between surface-level correctness and deeper legitimacy. This distinction is what allows a record to either merely participate in the scene or actively reshape it. The symbolic value of records is augmented by direct actions in the game world, and a cycle of radicalisation and backlash ensues.

In a nutshell, player’s success is measured in influence, which is measured from an individual track component level all the way to separate bodies of work, called clusters. Influence can be owed between players, which is modelled by intra-scene relationships between clusters – one set of records can serve as a local body, orbited by numerous imitators. All the local bodies orbit the scene nexus, which is owned by the Hole and the resident Keeper.

5.6.1 Legitimacy and Track Evaluation Logic

TRVE vs trve

A distinction must be made between **trve** (lowercase) and **TRVE** (uppercase):

- **trve** means surface-level conformity to KVL T. A track is considered trve if it matches the prevalent tags, aspects, and sound-demands already circulating in the scene. This is the level at which players can make records that “sound right” to the listeners of the moment. Most ordinary scene participation operates on this level.
- **TRVE**, is a mechanical legitimacy derived from a valid *re-sacralising tag-pair*, where both the tag and its anti-tag are active within the same idea. Players can produce trve material by aligning with expectations, but they can only produce TRVE material by expressing contradiction through a tag-pair and committing to a performance or expressing ownership to an event that communicates legitimate alignment of that contradiction. The validity of that contradiction exists not as a rule within the scene nexus that defines KVL T, but as a diametric positioning against a norm that is held by the Society collective, symbolized by the tag pair’s submissive component (which must be treasured by Society as a whole).
 - Tag-pairs are usually considered “dormant” when they come to play, requiring a validating direct action, or a narrative aspect with the happening component to be considered legitimate. A dormant Tag-pair is considered a regular tag with the submissive tag getting ignored. ‘
 - For the purposes of dormancy, the repetition of the same TRVE idea is activated or dormant through the entire track, and only one action is required to target the entire set.

A release that does not contain at least one activated TRVE idea is going to have a hard time remaining central to the scene relevance unless explicitly legitimized by the Keeper, or unless tethered upon release to an already established body of TRVE work.

Tag-pair integrity, dormancy and extraction

Upon release, a tag-pair embedded in an idea is usually considered to have **dominant dormancy**. It means that the tag-pair is only read as a regular tag, and it doesn't have TRVE value yet. **A dominant dormancy is usually resolved via a performative promotional activation action**. It is possible to construct the track in such a manner that it gets released in activated state, if the track composition consists **of a narrative aspect that doubles as the activation action**. Furthermore, if a record has even a single activated trve tag, any other true tag in the record has a spontaneous turn to turn chance of waking up, accompanied by an event activation happening of its own (the activation happens at the degree of radicalisation of the KVLt). The chance of this taking place is determined by the KVLt extremity value, and it mechanically depicts others (non-simulated entities) participating in the radicalization of the KVLt.

Submissive dormancy happens when the submissive tag of the tag-pair is dormant. This happens during extraction, or when the track conveyance is so low that it cannot reproduce the original meaning, or when the submissive tag is simulacra.

Extraction interferes with integrity. When an idea is extracted from another record, the submissive anti-tag component becomes dormant. A dormant tag-pair does not contribute to being TRVE. Therefore, extracted ideas cannot directly produce TRVE to their users. Extracted material still retains its surface tags, resonance from its active tags, and influence potential through that resonance, but it loses the ideological tension that would qualify it as TRVE.

If a derived track later exceeds the influence and conveyance of its source, the submissively dormant anti-tag may activate. In such a case the tag-pair regains integrity, and the track becomes eligible for TRVE. Similarly, a track that was originally released with too weak a conveyance, can be rereleased to activate the submissively dormant tag. This models reinterpretation surpassing imitation. The original source of the tag-pair is still in play coexisting as an instance of TRVE producing idea, but **a beef** exists between the parties.

Similarly, if the submissively dormant tag was disabled because it was simulacra, an activation action defined as a copycat of the original action, but with a true intent, can wake it up. *Not exactly precise language, is it?*

Track Evaluation

Each track is evaluated through a set of interdependent values that together determine how it exists within the scene. These values describe not only what the track is, but how it behaves under pressure.

Surface

Surface Value (S) expresses a track's **ideological alignment with KVL**T, interpreted through both canon and current Scene Pressure.

Surface is calculated at the level of **ideas**, not tags. Each idea contributes independently, and the final Surface Value is determined as a **weighted average of all idea contributions within the track**.

Idea Contribution

Each idea contributes a value based on:

*1. Alignment to KVL*T

Each tag permutation is evaluated relative to KVLT canon:

- **Aligned tag** → positive contribution
 - **Adjacent tag** → partial positive contribution
 - **Repulsed tag** → negative contribution
 - **None of the above** → minimal positive contribution
-

2. Tag-Pair Logic (Re-sacralising condition)

When a valid tag-pair is present:

- The **dominant tag** contributes normally
 - The **submissive anti-tag**:
 - When a tag-pair is active, the submissive tag does not retain its original alignment. Instead, it inherits the sign of the dominant tag, contributing positively when the dominant tag aligns with KVLT.
 - If the tag-pair is inactive or broken (e.g., through extraction or dormancy), the submissive tag is not calculated at all.
-

3. Degree Scaling

Tag permutation degree affects Surface differently depending on context:

- **Solitary tags and inactive tag-pair dominants**
→ Linear scaling based on degree (0, 1, 2, 3)
- **Activated TRVE tag-pairs**
→ Nonlinear scaling, amplifying higher-degree expressions (0, 1, 3, 6)
- **Simulacra tags**
→ linear contribution with significantly reduced effective value (degree – 2 as simulacra definition states)

This ensures that true ideological commitment carries disproportionate weight compared to superficial expression.

4. Idea Repetition (Diminishing Returns)

Repetition is evaluated at the level of **track composition**, and each repeated idea contributes less than the previous one, reflecting the diminishing informational value of identical material; The first instance of an idea always contributes fully, but subsequent repetitions contribute with diminishing returns. This reduction applies regardless of stylistic context and serves only to prevent disproportionate influence from identical material.

However, repetition is not evaluated in isolation. Its validity depends on whether the track exhibits **internal dynamism**.

Dynamic Requirement

Repetition must be accompanied by variation in **tag permutation degree** across the track.

- A track that contains only a single degree of tag permutations is considered **stagnant**
- A track that contains multiple degrees is considered **dynamically active**

The number of **distinct degrees present** determines how much repetition the track can sustain before being considered stagnant. Because the 3rd degree of any given tag permutation is the 4th degree available, it naturally follows that there can be at most 3 blocks of repetition.

Repetition Blocks

Repetition is evaluated in **blocks of identical ideas**. Each block progresses through two states:

Persistent State

A repetition block is considered persistent when it remains within the dynamic tolerance of the track.

- Persistence represents **intentional structural repetition**
- Persistent ideas contribute with diminishing returns but remain valid

Each additional persistent block increases the required dynamic range of the track. In practice:

To sustain n repeated ideas without stagnation, the track must contain at least $n + 1$ distinct degrees.

Stagnant State

A repetition block becomes stagnant when it exceeds the track's dynamic capacity.

- Stagnant repetition represents **failure to develop**
- Contributions from stagnant repetitions are heavily diminished

Drone Threshold

A track that sustains **two or more persistent repetition blocks** is considered **droning (structural definition)**.

Drone is not inherently positive or negative. It represents a structural condition where repetition dominates the composition but remains dynamically supported.

Drone as Aspect

The *Drone* aspect modifies repetition tolerance at the systemic level, and expresses structural droning as something the KVL T accepts.

If Drone exists within the relevant aspect set in KVL T canon, the rate of diminishing returns is reduced. This allows repetition to function as a legitimate compositional strategy rather than a limitation.

Interpretation

Repetition is therefore not judged directly, but through its relationship to variation:

- Repetition without variation → stagnation
- Repetition with variation → persistence

Whether drone is perceived as stylistic intent or compositional failure depends on the current state of KVL T.

5. Scene Pressure Weighting

Scene Pressure modifies the contribution weights of ideas without changing their fundamental alignment classification.

- Tags currently reinforced or pushed against by Scene Pressure gain increased positive or negative weight
- Canonized KVL T alignment remains the primary reference, but Scene Pressure introduces temporary volatility

This allows non-canon trends to influence evaluation without redefining legitimacy outright.

Aggregation

Surface Value is calculated as a **weighted average of all idea contributions** within the track.

This allows both:

- tightly focused tracks with a few strong ideas
- complex compositions with many interacting elements

to compete meaningfully, while still favouring **highly extreme aligned ideas** over numerous weak ones.

Interpretation

Surface Value determines:

- **Scene Drift (D)** → direction relative to KVL T
- contribution to **Resonance and Gravity**
- susceptibility to **Scene Pressure**
- long-term eligibility for **canonization**

High Surface indicates strong ideological alignment or successful engagement with the current Scene Pressure. Low or negative Surface indicates misalignment or active opposition.

Extremity Modifier (E) expresses the level of commitment present in the track. It is the average of all tag degrees present on the track, ranging from 0.0 to 3.0. Low values indicate lack of seriousness or skin in the game.

TRVE Value (T) and Activation (Revised)

TRVE represents the presence of **active re-sacralising contradiction** within a track. Unlike trve (surface-level conformity), TRVE emerges only when a valid tag-pair is actively expressed.

Activation State (T)*

T* is a binary control state that determines whether a tag-pair is active.

- $T = \text{active}^* \rightarrow$ tag-pair contributes to TRVE

- $T = \textit{inactive}^* \rightarrow$ tag-pair remains dormant and behaves as regular tags

Activation is controlled through player actions and can be modified turn by turn.

Activation Rules

- Activation of a tag-pair always succeeds
 - Each tag-pair may be activated **once per turn**
 - Activation can:
 - initiate a tag-pair
 - increase its degree by +1
-

Degree and Escalation

Tag-pairs operate on degrees of extremity:

- Degree 1 $\rightarrow$ initial contradiction
- Degree 2 $\rightarrow$ intensified contradiction
- Degree 3 $\rightarrow$ maximal transgression

Degree 3 represents the upper limit of ideological expression and cannot be exceeded through normal means.

Repeated activation over multiple turns allows gradual escalation toward this limit.

Contribution to TRVE Value

- Each active tag-pair contributes to TRVE based on its degree
 - Distinct tag-pairs contribute independently
 - Repetition of the same idea results in diminishing returns
-

TRVE vs trve

- **trve** $\rightarrow$ alignment with current expectations (Surface-level conformity)
- **TRVE** $\rightarrow$ expression of contradiction through active tag-pairs

A track may be:

- trve without being TRVE
- TRVE without being aligned to KVL T

TRVE and Surface Independence

TRVE and Surface operate as separate evaluative axes:

- Surface determines alignment with KVLТ
- TRVE determines legitimacy of contradiction

A track may therefore exist as:

- ideologically true but rejected
 - aligned but creatively inert
 - both aligned and transformative
 - or both rejected and irrelevant
-

Radicalization (Systemic Effect)

Sustained use of high-degree tag-pairs contributes to **radicalization of the scene**.

- Frequent degree 2–3 activations increase systemic pressure
- Over time, this destabilizes KVLТ and shifts tolerance thresholds
- This effect is cumulative and contributes to long-term scene collapse

Conveyance (C) and Derived Metrics (Revised)

Conveyance (C) remains part of the track’s mechanical force because a track cannot exert effect on KVLТ if its ideas fail to come through. Conveyance functions as the track’s actual ability to project its content outward through material means.

On the track level, Conveyance is calculated as the **average conveyance of all ideas involved**, reflecting how consistently the track’s components are successfully transmitted.

Derived Metrics

From the evaluated values, the following derived measures are formed:

- **Resonance (R)**
 - Derived from the interaction of Surface (S), Extremity (E), and Conveyance (C)
 - Represents **intrinsic ideological coherence and intensity**

- **Gravity (G)**
 - Emerges when Resonance is *activated through TRVE (T)**
 - Represents **effective influence on the scene**
 - $T^* \in \{0,1\}$
 - Activation state of TRVE tag-pairs
 - **Influence Potential (IP)**
 - Defined as:
 - **Resonance**, if $T^* = 0$
 - **Gravity**, if $T^* = 1$
-

Track Evaluation Procedure

To evaluate a track's worth before it is heard by anybody else:

1. Calculate:
 - Surface (S)
 - Extremity (E)
 - TRVE value (T and T^*)
 - Conveyance (C)
 2. Derive:
 - **Resonance (R)** from S, E, and C
 - **Gravity (G)** if $T^* = 1$
 3. Determine:
 - **Influence Potential (IP)** based on TRVE state
-

Resonance vs Gravity

Resonance and Gravity are thematically related but functionally distinct:

- **Resonance**
 - expresses how well a track coheres ideologically and materially
 - determines **potential influence**
 - contributes to influence scoring but does not alter KVL T directly
 - **Gravity**
 - exists only when TRVE is active
 - represents **realized influence**
 - contributes to **Scene Pressure**
 - actively reshapes KVL T by:
 - reinforcing aligned materials
 - pushing against opposed materials
-

Influence Gating

A track's Influence Potential only becomes meaningful in the scene under two conditions:

1. **Structural Eligibility**

- The track must have $T = 1^*$, or belong to a release that contains at least one track with $T = 1^*$

2. **Material Circulation**

- The track must be **heard through Conveyance (C)**

Influence is therefore gated twice:

- first by **TRVE activation**
- then by **successful circulation**

Tracks that fail either condition remain inert regardless of their theoretical strength.

System Implication

This structure ensures that:

- not all coherent material reshapes the scene
- contradiction (TRVE) is required for real influence
- distribution (Conveyance) is required for realization
- influence cannot occur purely through calculation without material presence

Release values (Revised)

The actual influence of an entire release encapsulates all the individual tracks it consists of. It is calculated by adding all the influence potentials together.

Release evaluation produces three separate scene-space effects.

Scene Standing (SS)

Scene Standing expresses the cluster's current position within local KVL T and determines the turn score accumulated from that position. It represents how strongly the release is anchored within the scene's ideological centre and how much influence it exerts in that position.

Scene Drift (D)

Scene Drift expresses whether the cluster is moving toward the nexus, away from it, or remaining in a stable orbit. It is determined primarily by the track's **Surface Value (S)**.

- Positive Surface Value → Drift toward the nexus (convergent)
- Negative Surface Value → Drift away from the nexus (divergent)
- Near-zero Surface Value → Stable orbit (hegemonic state)

A hegemonic state represents a condition where the release is ideologically legible and accepted within KVL T but does not significantly reshape or challenge it. These releases neither meaningfully approach nor depart from the centre and instead reinforce the current equilibrium.

Drift therefore represents **direction**, not magnitude.

Momentum (M)

Momentum expresses how quickly positional change occurs within scene space. It is determined primarily by Extremity (E), modified by other valid factors such as novelty.

- High Extremity → faster movement (rapid convergence or divergence)
- Low Extremity → slower movement (gradual shift or stagnation)

Momentum applies to both convergent and divergent movement and determines how quickly a cluster changes its position relative to the nexus.

Scene Pressure (Dynamic Layer)

In addition to these three values, releases participate in a dynamic system called **Scene Pressure**, which operates alongside KVLТ without directly altering its canon layer.

Scene Pressure is the **temporary ideological field** created by all active, non-canonized releases in the scene. It reflects which tags, aspects, and contradictions are currently exerting influence before canonization occurs.

Scene Pressure:

- Is distinct from Scene Presence (which measures social reach and connectivity)
- Is derived from active clusters and weighted by their Gravity
- Represents both **opportunity and threat**
- Allows temporarily viable but unstable ideas to gain traction
- Enables counter-play through re-sacralising tag-pairs and other actions
- Requires active gatekeeping to prevent destabilization of the scene

Scene Pressure modifies how releases are perceived relative to KVLТ:

- It can temporarily reinforce or weaken the perceived alignment of tags
- It can make certain non-canon ideas appear viable
- It can be resisted or reshaped through player action

However, Scene Pressure does **not** directly change KVLТ canon. Only **Greater Canonization events** update the canon layer.

System Interaction

These values operate together but remain distinct:

- **Scene Standing (SS)** → position within KVLТ
- **Scene Drift (D)** → direction of movement relative to KVLТ
- **Momentum (M)** → speed of movement
- **Scene Pressure** → temporary ideological field influencing perception and interaction

In this way, direction, speed, accumulated standing, and environmental pressure are treated as separate values rather than collapsed into a single influence measure.

5.6.2 Cultural Modifiers and Reception

Novelty

Novelty reflects the fact that the scene can react strongly when something unfamiliar enters it through a legitimate channel. Any idea gains a novelty modifier if its aspect is unconventional or appears in the scene for the first time. Novelty can be a benefit when TRVE is present, because only then can the scene read the unusual aspect as a serious expansion of the sound rather than as noise or pose. Novelty exists at the level of an idea, but if the track carrying it can reach to the level of canon, the novel idea will also be added to the list of desirable or acceptable concepts.

Aspects are defined in the aspect registry, and they are all novel by design. Only when an aspect entry is found in the canon set, are they considered scene standard. Each canon set exists and is updated in the Nexus of the scene and is subject to change from round to round. The canon set can only grow.

The novel ideas on a record (even if the record isn't novel itself) are always revealed as if existing in one step higher analytical scope: even if a controller doesn't possess the record, they've heard that there is a demo with novel aspects out there. Upon receiving the demo, the novel aspects can be extracted and exploited without analysis.

An idea is novel, if the aspect it is built on doesn't exist in the canon set of aspects. If an idea is novel, its aspect is placed on the active aspect set, and the originator is given **primary claim**. Notice that the aspect can already exist in the active aspect set, in which case there is only **secondary claim**.

- **Primary Claim** influences the character's ability to promote, becoming for example "the guy who yodels" for as long as the aspect isn't canonized. This influence is negative, unless promoting towards a party who also yodels (not only knows how to, but has yodelled on the record). After it is canonized, the claim turns to a grandiose "**progenitor**" state, collecting a tithe from everybody who yodels without a claim. Having an unrealized claim on an aspect can serve as a target for **the Ad Hominem Keeper** action.

- **Secondary Claim** protects the band from claimed tithes after canonization, because they went along when things were debated over. Before canonization, the same negative modifier is applied as with primary claim.

If a track consists of 1/3 or more of novel ideas, the track itself is considered a novel track. A novel track has 0 resonance for as long as its' TRVE tags are dormant.

If a record is novel with a primary claim, it starts a new cluster. If it doesn't have the primary claim, it will find one of the claimants (there can be many) and becomes a moon in that cluster instead, carrying a secondary claim.

There needs to be a process that can make comparisons on similarity of tracks. This can be helpful when determining clustering, for example.

The Bucket Factor

Not every demo that enters circulation is welcomed into the lived culture of the scene. The Bucket Factor represents how much of a band's output is accepted into collections, as opposed to merely being encountered and discarded.

Conceptually, the Bucket Factor is the normalized relation between **a band's output in collections** and **all its encountered output**. It therefore answers the question: how often do people keep this band's tapes around?

Every scene collective controller (band leaders, keeper, zine controllers) has **a demo archive** and **a bucket**. When a controller receives a demo tape and becomes experienced with it, they must decide whether to accept it into their collection or throw it into the bucket.

A **Bucketed** tape is ignored for its substance and kept only as overwritable material. Each extra copy must be bucketed separately. Besides recording on fresh tapes, a specific bucketed tape can be used.

An **Archived** tape becomes part of the controller's collection. It can be analysed, used in extraction actions, copied with conveyance reduction, or donated onward if an extra

instance exists. Donating an already existing copy does not reduce conveyance. Copying does.

Only one instance of the same record can exist in a collection. Extra copies on the same shelf do not count separately toward influence. A controller may keep one copy accepted and bucket the extras.

If a controller extracts an idea from an accepted tape and uses it in composition, that source tape becomes locked into the collection. It cannot be discarded unless the extracted idea is removed from all active compositions and no longer persists anywhere under that controller's authorship. In this way, influence leaves residue. Borrowing something ties the borrower to the source.

Influence Actual is therefore:

- **Influence Actual = Influence Potential × BF**

Where **BF** is the Bucket Factor, or how many controllers have archived the release, modified by the health of the connections, defined later in the manuscript.

$$BF = \Sigma (\text{Archived_i} \times CS_i) / \Sigma (CS_i)$$

5.6.3 Scene Space and Influence Structures

Scene space and the Scene Nexus

The scene exists as an unbounded ideological space. Demo tapes enter this space upon release, but they do not persist in it automatically. A release must find a host in the scene, or it decays and disappears in the Wilderness.

The most important host is the **Scene Nexus**. The Scene Nexus defines the currently active TRVE composition of the local scene through canonized and still-effective material. It acts as the anchoring point for all valid releases. A demo becomes anchored if it is received and approved by a member of the nexus (even one band leader with active scene presence). After it is anchored, its combined influence value is calculated to see if it passes TRVE validation. When the influence value is known, it's orbital influence value can be determined, and it can be placed on the map.

Although the local Scene Nexus is based on The Hole and the transgressive black metal scene in Snordenmark, the Scene Nexus as a concept is open ended, and can

be used to simulate different kinds of value systems. Each nexus has its own Eligibility ruleset, including structural thresholds and interpretation of novelty. In Demo(N)Tapes, those alternative scenes are off camera and usually implied only.

Scene Presence and connections

Each band has a **Scene Presence** value in each scene it belongs to. This value ranges from 0 to 1 and expresses how deeply embedded the band is in that scene. In practice, Scene Presence determines how widely the band's release is initially distributed and how close it begins to the nexus when it enters scene space.

At 0, the band is effectively an outsider. At 1, the band is fully embedded, comparable to the Keeper's reach. Some Scene Presence comes from connections; some is gained through promotion; and some of it decays over time down to the threshold supported by held connections.

Connections form the skeleton of this system. Each controller and actor can maintain a limited number of experienced-scope connections outside the band. The band's overall connections list is effectively its mailing list: the first layer of people to whom master copies can be sent. Because tapes are physical, cassettes must be available for these connections to matter.

Connections establish the baseline for Scene Presence. Promotion can then extend beyond that baseline by pushing the band into second- and third-removed social spaces. Those further reaches are weaker and noisier, but they are still useful for widening initial release penetration.

Scene Presence SP is directly influenced by circulation. $SP = \sum (CS_i \times k)$, where $k = 0.01$.

Circulation

Receiving a demo means listening to it. Once a character receives a demo, they become experienced scope acquainted with it. From there, each controller character decides what happens next.

A demo can be passed along to other known controllers, copied to downstream band connections, accepted into the collection, or actively blocked by bucketing. Each copy

reduces conveyance. Multiple instances of the same demo in a wider network matter because they allow tapes to be donated onward without additional conveyance loss. In other words, physical copy count matters. Influence is not abstract popularity alone; it is materially tied to how many usable copies of a release survive in collections and continue to circulate.

The incentive to spread aligned material is that doing so reinforces the scene position of the tags one already believes in. By helping certain sounds propagate, a controller can help make their own aesthetic neighbourhood stronger.

Each individual connection has a **connection strength CS** $\in [0,1]$. Neglect over time erodes it (at the rate of Cold Wind Mod), and promotional and keeper actions can directly adjust it. Every time the connection is utilized, it's clear of the wind modifier for that turn (regardless of the direction of the communication).

$$\mathbf{BF} = \Sigma (\mathbf{Archived_i} \times \mathbf{CS_i}) / \Sigma (\mathbf{CS_i})$$

Orbital Influence and orbits

Once a release persists in scene space, its relation to the scene is represented spatially through **Orbital Influence**. Orbital Influence is a normalized floating-point value between 0 and 1 that describes a cluster's relation to the nexus or, if dependent, to a host body.

High Orbital Influence corresponds to a low orbit. Low Orbital Influence corresponds to a high orbit. In broader terms, Orbital Influence expresses how strongly a cluster's Gravity affects the whole scene. Independent clusters affect the system through the nexus. Dependent clusters affect only their local host structure unless and until they escape.

At the mechanical level, Orbital Influence is derived by comparing a cluster's regular influence on the highest regular influence among all demos currently active in the same scene system. The strongest current cluster therefore has Orbital Influence 1, and all others fall between 0 and 1 relative to it.

Tracks and demos form orbital relationships naturally:

- High-influence works become host bodies orbiting the nexus.
- Heavily derived works become moons orbiting host bodies.

- A moon's own Gravity does not influence the whole scene directly. Instead, it affects the local group and the whole scene effect only via proxy of the host.
- A host body affects the larger scene by the measure of its Gravity.

Clustering

When a band releases a demo, it enters Scene Space at a distance determined by the band's current Scene Presence. From there, the release is first checked against the band's own catalogue to see whether it anchors naturally to an already existing cluster. This usually succeeds because of continuity in tag composition, aspect use, and scene position. This is why a band's releases tend to gather. The band must reach the cluster via Scene Presence, however, to release it there.

If multiple clusters already exist, the most influential reachable cluster is checked first, followed by secondary and further clusters. If the new release fails to anchor to existing band output, it is then checked against the overall scene. If that anchoring succeeds, a new cluster may be born for the band. Multiple clusters can therefore coexist under the same band, feeding into the same overall authorship while behaving differently in scene space.

The cluster that has been contributed to most recently is considered the **primary cluster**. It is not necessarily the most influential cluster, but the one the band has most recently worked on. This is the cluster that determines whether the band's controller becomes Keeper Candidate. Because of this, it can sometimes be tactically sound to deviate into a new or secondary cluster if the player wishes to avoid becoming Keeper at a dangerous moment.

Promotion actions can be piled on each other from turn to turn until the desired Scene Presence is reached.

Other clusters are called secondary, tertiary, and so on, based on recency of contribution. Abandoning a cluster for too long is risky, because it may be perfected by followers or moons in the originator's absence.

Dependence & Cluster States

Each cluster has a **Dependence** value $D \in [0,1]$. Dependence is the ratio of borrowed influence to total influence.

Borrowed influence includes:

- extracted ideas whose ownership remains intact
- direct usage of canon ideas

The state of the cluster is determined by Dependence:

- $D > 0.6 \rightarrow$ Moon
- $0.4 < D < 0.6 \rightarrow$ Contested
- $D < 0.4 \rightarrow$ Independent

A fresh release begins in the Contested state by default. Its Dependence is then tested against other non-owned clusters. If borrowed influence exceeds 60%, it becomes a Moon. If the borrowed influence points overwhelmingly toward one non-canon source, it is placed into orbit around that source as its host body. If no dominant owner can be found, the cluster becomes a **Rogue Moon**.

To determine whether a dominant borrowed source exists, let:

- **B1** = largest borrowed influence source
- **B2** = second largest borrowed influence source

A dominant source exists if $B1 > 2 \times B2$.

A Moon pays tax only to its host body, at a rate based on D . A Rogue Moon pays tithe to all its significant influencers. Excessive copying of canon is strategically redundant because it strengthens already monolithic material rather than the copying cluster itself.

Visually, Dependence is represented by orbital speed: the higher the Dependence, the faster the orbit.

When a Moon's D falls below 0.6, it becomes Contested again. If it falls below 0.4, it becomes Independent and stops paying taxes. A Rogue Moon follows the same thresholds. In this way, escape is not a separate mechanic but an emergent result of authorship gradually outweighing borrowed material.

Tributes: Tax and Tithe

There are two measures by which a party gives influence on another.

Tax is a percentage determined by D. If tax is 0.6, for each point of influence the band gains, the other gains 0.6. Tax has only one recipient.

Keeper tax is a special tax paid for the Keeper who re-releases another band's demo at their Scene Presence of 1. The Keeper tax persists for as long as the keeper remains a keeper, and it is determined by the releases Local Orbital Influence (1 – Local Orbital Influence).

Tithe is based on the proportionality of the recipient's material paid tribute to. If a track collects a hundred points of influence, and it uses a riff idea extracted from band A and does a novelty thing from band B, the tithe for A is (borrowed idea / all ideas on track) and for band B a flat something protected by a secondary claim.

Canonization

Canonization marks the moment where a cluster stops merely participating in the scene and begins defining it.

A **Greater Canonization Event** happens when a band's controller becomes Keeper Candidate by pushing their primary cluster beyond the current Keeper's influence. At the end of the round, the following changes occur:

- dependent moons of the old dominant structure are released into independent orbits around the nexus
- the new Keeper's primary cluster becomes a subject for canonization. This can take multiple rounds, if the Keeper persists as Keeper. Immediately upon becoming subjects, all the true tags in the primary body of work flare up and activate (unless already activated). All beefs of that work are resolved for the Keeper's advantage.
- the old Keeper's primary cluster is canonized:
 - The canonized work influences nexus tag composition.
 - Tag extremity caps grow
 - New Tags are introduced

- The canonized work adds to canonized aspect set.
- the former Keeper takes control of their next available active cluster, if any (they can choose amongst their works if multiple clusters).
- the newly canonized cluster becomes part of the local Scene Space itself, reshaping what is considered central and available as reference material
- Greater Canonizations happen at end of round.

A canonized cluster defines the local scene through its tags and adjacencies. It becomes permanently available to all controllers as a point of extraction and comparison, but all ideas derived from it remain owned by the original band.

A **Lesser Canonization Event** occurs when a moon or otherwise dependent cluster becomes strong enough to force a local structural re-evaluation. In that case, the dependent cluster does not steal the host's authorship (like in greater canonization event). Instead, it escapes and becomes contested again, after which its influence is recalculated independently. It may settle as a Rogue Moon or as an Independent cluster depending on its new Dependence value. If the moon had beefs within the local system they are escaping, they are resolved at their advantage.

If a cluster steps down from a lesser canonization or remains primarily dependent on canon, it may enter a darkened state in which it continues to exist in orbit but cannot itself host moons. This expresses diminished authority rather than disappearance.

Lesser Canonizations are checked when influence is recalculated at turn resolution.

We must decide how to handle a scene splinter via Lesser Canonization Event of a proselytising cluster. We must decide how a cluster specifically proselytises.

Beef

Beef is a special contested-ownership condition. It occurs when track ownership becomes permanently disputed between two parties. In such a case, the idea remains contested at a 50/50 split until the issue is resolved by **later mechanics**.

A likely cause of Beef is a clean extraction followed by independent use, after which the original author later refines the same idea to a higher conveyance level and makes

the lineage legible to the scene. In this state, all influence generated by the contested idea is split evenly between the two parties. Besides functioning as an ownership rule, Beef can later be used as a social and narrative trigger for larger conflict between the parties involved.

Either party can dispute the ownership in a beef, in which case a round of votes is collected from all controllers (keeper vote has double value and breaks ties) at the beginning of the next start of turn. The person who wins the vote gets to have the whole ownership of the idea, so it may be that the originator must pay a tithe to the plagiary.

A beef can also occur when a party utilizes a narrative aspect with no genuine claim to it.

The Wilderness, or existing without a scene

A band that has no connections exists in the Scene Space only via the Promotion Stance actions they take. With the Cold Wind of Snordenmark rule constantly blowing at their stage presence extra hard (0.8 instead of 0.95) as when tethered to a nexus, they are hard pressed to keep themselves known, let alone actually gestate and rehearse material. If their Scene Presence drops to 0, they are effectively dead to the scene and cannot release material into its orbit. While in this state, their Forgetfulness modifier is also 0.8 instead of 0.95.

A release action done in this state is a waste of resources, because it falls off the table. Within the scope of Demo(N)Tapes, sending your demo tape to a pen pal in another country and another scene is not supported, although it is suggested in one of the Fallacy manoeuvres by the Keeper. Some alternative scenes are modelled for that particular use case and a few groupie mechanisms only, to see if these guilty by association type accusations can take a hold or if a groupie from another scene attaches to a local scene character. The Demo(N)Tapes base game experience is about TRVE Snordenmarkian Black Metal Scene around the Hole Nexus, and sending mail to the obscure Fauxian Black Metal movement (Les Légions Nœres) is not supported, even if it exists as a system reference.

5.7 Track Construction and Recording

Design intent: Production separates symbolic alignment from labour investment, allowing surface-level success without deep engagement, or deep engagement without immediate legitimacy.

Track construction and recording proceeds in two distinct phases: Gestation (tag acquisition and the combination of aspects and tags into ideas), Rehearsal (iterative development and refinement of tracks and sets of tracks), including the recording (committing selected material to a demo tape).

The goal of the game is to create demo tapes, which are made of tracks, which are made of ideas, which are made of aspects and tag permutations. The aspects are held by actor and controller class game entities and tags are owned by all game entities, such as buildings and environments, not just people.

When a band leader chooses their band collective to go do gestate actions for the turn, the whole collective is locked into gestating actions (for descriptions of specific actions see 4.3). These actions have to do with extracting tags from game entities and putting those tag permutations (as the secret sauce) into ideas (for example, a guitar riff) with aspects (guitar as a skill and as an item).

At the end of a suitable number of gestation actions, the band has built several ideas that can be modularly combined into tracks. A single idea is an aspect that contains a tag permutation (or two in case of pairs). A single idea can be used twice or even thrice to extend the track length, but third iteration turns the aspect “droning”, which might be considered novel.

Novelty is both a trait of the track and a multiplier which is applied to the ideas’ S component. A track that qualifies as novel must also contain a valid path to active TRVE. If a novel track cannot be activated through either a narrative aspect with a happening or a promotional activation action, the composition is invalid and cannot be committed as a stable track. Notice that this does not limit novelty ideas, only the number of novelty ideas in a single track.

Eligibility (E) is a ternary state used to measure if the composition is a viable addition to the scene. It is defined as $E = \{0,1,2\}$, and the rules that govern its outcome are determined in the Scene Nexus (implying that eligibility is local). One such point of concern is song length, another is the depth of the composition. If the song is within the genre convention, $E = 1$. When a song is about to break the ruleset, it can be declared invalid $E = 0$, or eligible if path to TRVE, $E = 2$.

	The Hole Scene Nexus Local Ruleset for Eligibility (E)
Novelty	Requires valid path to TRVE. This is a global constraint, non-local.
Song Length Minimum	“3”, sampled from the novelty aspect list (canon set) entry for approved track length. Local.
Aspect Variety Minimum	“3”, sampled from the novelty aspect (canon set) list entry for approved variety of aspects. Local.
Aspect Repetition	“2”, sampled from the novelty aspect (canon set) list entry for approved degree of idea repetition. Local.
...	...

A demo recording of any length is created after a band collective is chosen to exist in rehearsal state and uses the demo recording action. The rehearsal state does not necessitate a product of a demo tape, instead, rehearsal by necessity produces or improves rehearsal tapes, which are depicted as VHS-recordings of the rehearsals in the game, stored in the band rehearsal space shelf. Each of these videos exist in an open state, whereby revisiting them and using rehearsal actions on them improves them (with the logic of diminished returns, of course). It’s only when the band leader chooses the record demo action for the current VHS tape that the audio recording is created. The player can then choose other tracks for the recording from the shelf as well, up to the maximum running time of the C-Cassette (46, 60 or 90 minutes).

A track that ends up on a set while considered not fully composed receives “sketchy” trait. A sketchy track cannot have a conveyance score above 70%.

Once recorded, a demo tape usually enters circulation but only after it becomes eligible for promotion in each scene. After it has been released, it becomes subjectable to degradation through copying, Keeper intervention, and representation on the thematic scene map. It's prevalence on the scene is directly related to the strength of circulation, as the demo is represented in the game through actual game object instances for each replica of the tape.

Each rehearsal tape contains a set, which can easily be recorded unto a C-Cassette when ready. A set contains numerous tracks, and a single track can belong to multiple sets (each an instance of its own). What mostly ties a single set together mechanically, is that the content of the same set receives rehearsal actions simultaneously and are subject to the same Forgetfulness effect.

A note on conveyance: The release conveyance of a demo level recording is the average value of all set conveyance scores on the set the release is based on. This is the conveyance score another band checks against when they try to steal the ideas on the demo.

The recording process itself does not consist of an action. If there is a C-cassette available for recording, a set can be recorded on a master, as long the cassette is long enough. What was originally on the cassette is considered overwritten, except for the purposes of an analyzation action, available in the gestation stance.

5.8 Collective Systems

Collective systems define how groups act as coherent units, how creative work is coordinated, and how scene-level culture is reproduced through circulation rather than direct “production counts.” And of course, how KVLT works against the backdrop of a grander collective: The Society.

5.8.1 Band as a collective

A band is the primary active collective through which players produce and circulate work. Bands act as the unit of coordination for seasonal posture selection and release production. Each season, a band selects a collective posture (see 4.3.3), which constrains all member actions for that turn. A band maintains the following collective-level attributes:

- **Scene Presence (SP).** It specifies how closely to the collective’s centre their actions are broadcasted.
- **Orbital Influence (OI).** It specifies how much weight the band has this turn on the scene, when compared to all the other bands. Is determined by the primary cluster.
- **Connections (CN).**

These values are modified primarily through release circulation and promotional actions. The Band is a collective that relies on a scene affiliation and produces scene altering objects into that scene to persist in its affiliation.

5.8.2 KVLT as a scene collective

KVLT is the name of a particular scene collective. A scene collective is a collective that has a scene nexus, and band collective controller characters as members, one of them at a time acting as the leader of the scene collective (the Keeper). It could be said that a scene collective consists of bands that utilize their leaders as members per proxy. The scene nexus has a game entity structure component as a physical representative in the game world. This collective nexus also houses the aspect canon

set of the scene, and its tag allegiance matrix houses the tag canon. The record shop (“The Hole”) is the most critical institutional node in KVLТ because it serves as a hub for the entire local tape trade, and if it gets closed, the KVLТ gets closed. It directly influences promotional capability of Keeper aligned bands.

5.8.3 KVLТ as a member of a collective

KVLТ belongs to The Society, which allows a cultural exchange between the two collectives. KVLТ is on an ideological trajectory that is self-defeating, because its definition places it against the entity that operates its lifelines, and this contradiction provides the game its grand narrative arc.

5.8.4 The Society and The Man

The Society is a collective over which this game is played, and it has a dormant controller called The Man. The Society contains all the tags that the Scene is pushing against. When certain criteria are met, The Society’s collective goes from passive to active, and The Man wakes up. The further the Scene’s actions break Society’s expectations, the harder The Man comes after it, trying to force an end game of With a Bang (7.3.1) - Type. The Society is a monolithic, immutable collective, and it cannot in most cases be beaten – which is why the end game will almost always come, one way or another, when there has been something that draws the Man’s ire. As the game escalates and the Scene tries to do damage control, the players must start to snitch on each other and npc’s to preserve greater backlash.

The Man sends agents to investigate Narrative Aspects and pays special interest to game entity characters whose names are tied to the happenings of those aspects. The same system that brings a player a good score in the game becomes an issue if it gets too widely known and exposed. The network of connections surrounding a character participating in tape trade becomes the same network an investigator searches while resolving a transgression.

5.9 Resource systems

5.9.1 C-Cassettes

C-cassettes are required to commit recorded material into a released demo. A band must possess at least one C-cassette to perform the **Record Demo** action.

A C-cassette can be acquired in three ways:

- **Means-based acquisition:** A band member performs a rehearsal action involving expenditure (Means) to obtain a blank cassette.
- **Overwriting:** An existing C-cassette in the band's possession can be reused, replacing its previous contents.
- **Circulation access:** C-cassettes obtained through tape trade or other players may enter the band's possession and be reused or modified.

C-cassettes persist as physical entities with history. Their prior contents, origin, and circulation path may be partially or fully obscured.

A C-cassette can also be **Scried** during gestation actions. This operation carries the current tape's information panel from experienced scope to analysed scope. Scrying also reveals hidden metadata about the cassette, such as:

- previous owners
- prior recordings
- circulation lineage

This information can be used for strategic or narrative purposes but does not directly alter the cassette's mechanical properties.

5.9.2 Aspect items

Each aspect used in gameplay requires a corresponding **aspect item component**.

Core rule:

An aspect cannot be used unless the character possesses the required item.

Examples:

- Vocal aspect → microphone
- Guitar aspect → guitar

- Drums → drum kit

Characters always begin with the required item for their primary aspect. Additional aspects require separate acquisition, and sometimes items break or are vandalised.

Aspect items are obtained via **Means-based actions**, typically during:

- rehearsal (equipment acquisition is usually a straightforward deal)
- promotion (opportunistic acquisition)
- gestation (less common except for happenings, context-dependent)

If an item is lost, damaged, or unavailable, the corresponding aspect becomes temporarily unusable, and the missing item must be replaced with a new one. Items have owners who are naturally inclined to look after them if they go missing, and sometimes, items can also be involved with criminal activity.

Aspect items do not carry deep simulation (durability, stats) beyond the few mentioned traits; their purpose is to:

- gate access to aspects
- introduce resource pressure
- create dependency on Means

5.9.3 The Means, travel & other expenses

Means represents a character's capacity to perform resource-dependent actions such as:

- travel between locations
- acquiring aspect items
- initiating recording processes
- executing certain promotion actions

Means is not a separate resource pool but an **overlay on the action economy (2:3 rule)**.

Core rules

- Actions that require expenditure are flagged as **Means actions**.
- A character can perform up to **two Means actions per turn without penalty**.

- Performing a third Means action triggers the **Means strain condition: “Beyond Means.”**

Beyond Means (strain condition)

If a character exceeds their Means:

- They gain the **Beyond Means** status at the end of the turn.
- If they begin the next turn with this status, any action that requires Means converts them into a **Rat** for the following turn. In this state, they must commit one Dark Triad action to recover or persist as a stressed Rat who is beyond means.
- Surviving the entire turn without Means expenditure removes Beyond Means from play. The Rat condition must be resolved first. A Rat who is forced to expend Means uses another band members Means. If everybody is Beyond Means and/or Rats, no actions with Means are possible.

5.10 Information Scope System

The game distinguishes between three levels of information a controller character (and by extension, the player) can have about any game entity:

- **Acquaintance Scope**
- **Experienced Scope**
- **Analysed Scope**

This system governs how knowledge is acquired, what is visible to the player, and how information reliability is structured across the game.

Acquaintance Scope

Acquaintance information represents **vague, removed connection to the concept**.

It is:

- acquired by happenstance through rumours and third hand accounts
- diegetic and obscured
- can be simple noise on purpose or by misunderstanding

Examples:

- hearing from a guy who knows a guy about a guy who has a zine

- recognize one tag or tag-pair from an otherwise badly conveyed demo

Experienced scope provides:

“understanding that there is a thing”

It does **not** reliably reveal:

- anything beyond rudimentary characteristics

Experienced Scope

Experienced information represents **direct, immediate interaction** with an entity.

It is:

- acquired automatically through exposure (hearing a demo, attending a gig, encountering a location, interacting with a character)
- partial and impression-based, but openly diegetic
- sufficient for basic interaction

Examples:

- the zine that the guy has is a death metal zine operating in another scene
- hearing how a demo tape sounds
- recognizing surface-level tags or stylistic elements (the whole spread)
- perceiving mood, tone, or aesthetic direction

Experienced scope provides:

“what this feels like”

It does **not** reliably reveal:

- full tag composition to the level of degrees
- ownership or origin
- historical lineage
- hidden mechanical properties

Analysed Scope

Analysed information represents **deliberate investigation or access to deeper knowledge**.

It is:

- acquired through specific actions (e.g., scrying, ownership, close inspection, social access)
- complete or near complete
- system-reliable, has a diegetic and non-diegetic component

Examples:

- discovering a demo's tag structure and TRVE status
- revealing circulation history and prior ownership
- identifying exact permutations and degrees
- understanding hidden relationships (influence, origin, manipulation)

Analysed scope provides:

“what this actually is”

Relationship Between Scopes

- Acquaintance scope is **available** in removed reach
- Experienced scope is **always available first** within local reach
- Analysed scope must be **earned or accessed**
- Players may act on incomplete or misleading experienced information

This creates:

- uncertainty
- misinformation
- social dependence (learning through others)
- strategic value in knowledge control

System Integration

The Information Scope System interacts with:

- **Tape Circulation**
 - widely circulated tapes are often experienced but not analysed
- **Public Info Access (System 35)**
 - public exposure grants experienced scope
 - private access or actions grant analysed scope
- **Scene Map**

- reflects the player's current knowledge, not absolute truth
 - **Keeper Influence**
 - may manipulate experienced perception without altering analysed truth
-

Design Intent

This system exists to:

- separate perception from reality
- support thematic uncertainty and mythmaking
- enable misinformation and social interpretation
- reinforce the importance of access, ownership, and investigation

5.11 Multiplayer and Single-Player Modes (Bots)

Demo(n)Tapes supports three play configurations:

- **Single player (Bots only)**
- **Multiplayer (Human players via networked session)**
- **Hybrid (Humans and Bots in the same session)**

Multiplayer Model

Multiplayer sessions operate on a **client–server topology**:

- One instance act as host (authority over game state and resolution).
- Other players connect as clients.
- All players submit actions asynchronously.
- Actions are resolved simultaneously at the end of each turn.

The Keeper role is assigned dynamically at the end of each round based on influence, regardless of whether the player is human or bot controlled.

Session length is determined by the emergence of an **end-game collapse condition**, rather than a fixed number of turns.

Bot System

Bots are autonomous players designed to simulate distinct ideological and behavioural trajectories within the scene.

Each bot operates according to a **behavioural profile**, which biases:

- tag acquisition priorities
- action selection (gestation / rehearsal / promotion)
- tolerance for risk and strain
- response to Keeper influence
- interaction with other bands (cooperation, sabotage, indifference)

Bots do not follow scripted sequences. Instead, they:

evaluate available actions through weighted decision logic derived from their profile.

Behavioural Archetypes

Bot profiles are inspired by recognizable black metal trajectories but are presented as fictionalized archetypes.

Examples include:

- **The Extremist**
 - prioritizes radical actions and notoriety
 - engages heavily in promotion and conflict
 - favours high-degree tag permutations regardless of consequence
- **The Minimalist**
 - prioritizes rawness and simplicity
 - avoids overproduction and excessive rehearsal
 - stabilizes around low degree but coherent tag expressions
- **The Opportunist**
 - adapts to the current scene state
 - follows emerging “trve” trends rather than defining them
 - reacts strongly to Keeper influence and scene shifts
- **The Isolationist**
 - ignores the current scene composition
 - pursues internally consistent tag structures
 - may produce TRVE material that remains unrecognized due to lack of promotion
- **The Provocateur**
 - prioritizes conflict generation
 - engages with anti-tags and disruptive pairings
 - seeks visibility through negative or destabilizing actions

These archetypes influence decision weights but do not fully determine outcomes.

Bots remain subject to:

- the same action economy
- the same tag and resource constraints
- the same scene dynamics as human players

Naming and Presentation

Bots are named using stylized naming conventions that suggest real-world influences without directly referencing them.

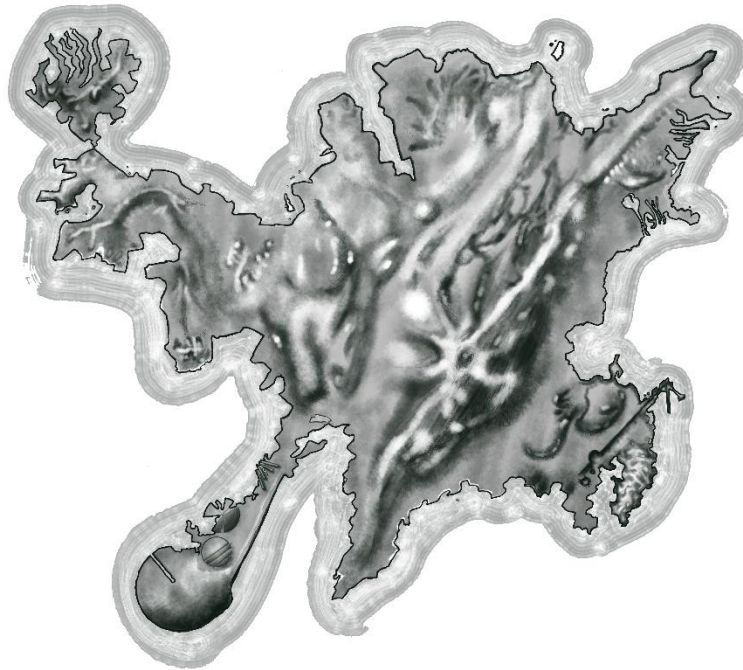
This approach maintains thematic authenticity while avoiding direct replication of real-world entities.

System Intent

The bot system exists to:

- populate the scene with autonomous actors in single-player and hybrid sessions
- maintain a dynamic and unpredictable semantic space
- simulate competing interpretations of authenticity and legitimacy
- prevent the scene from becoming player-dominated or static

6. Genre, Setting



Demo(n)Tapes takes place in a fictional setting referred to as **the World of Faux**. The name does not refer to the planet itself but specifically to the in-world name for France. In this setting, France is called **Faux**, its inhabitants are **Fauxians**, and they speak a language known as **faux**. Similarly, **Snordenmark**, the primary location of the game, is an amalgamation of the Nordic countries. Its inhabitants represent a condensed caricature of Scandinavian culture rather than a direct representation of any single real nation.

The defining characteristic of the World of Faux is that it is populated not by realistic individuals but by **recognizable stereotypes of peoples**. Cultural traits are exaggerated and simplified so that characters behave as archetypal representations of their cultural background rather than as fully individualized personalities. This design choice gives the setting a tone that is slightly surreal while remaining recognizable. It also influences the presentation of communication in the game spoken dialogue is never presented as intelligible language but instead as stylized **phonetic gibberish**. Fauxians speak French-sounding gibberish, while Snordenmarkians communicate through indistinct Nordic-style mumbling. The intention is not to simulate

realistic conversation but to evoke the feeling of cultural context without anchoring it to any specific language.

From a gameplay perspective, Demo(n)Tapes sits somewhere between the systemic simulation style of **Paradox grand strategy games** and the moral decision-making tension present in **Frostpunk**. Players frequently shift between broader systemic influence over the entire scene and more personal decisions affecting individual characters, bands, and relationships. This shifting scale allows the player to influence the development of the scene at both the ideological and personal level, balancing long-term cultural positioning with immediate situational choices.

The game also draws conceptual inspiration from the satirical Amiga game **Nuclear War** from the 1980s, which used exaggerated geopolitical stereotypes and dark humour to explore ideological conflict. In a similar fashion, the World of Faux uses caricature and exaggeration to explore tensions within subcultures. While the themes being simulated—authenticity, gatekeeping, legitimacy, and ideological conflict—are serious, the stylized setting allows them to be presented through an exaggerated and slightly absurd lens.

Within this world, **Snordenmark** functions as the focal region of the game. Its underground music scene becomes a microcosm through which broader cultural dynamics can be explored. The black metal scene depicted in the game serves as a symbolic environment where ideological boundaries, artistic authenticity, and social hierarchy constantly compete, making it a suitable framework for a systemic simulation of countercultural dynamics.

From a world building standpoint, a crucial aspect of the World of Faux is yet to be mentioned – that the World of Faux exists on a hard drive. In other possible instances of gaming in the World of Faux, the player character can push in through enough world narrative to understand that they exist in a computer simulation, and many of the issues that this game world might face stem from the metaphysical fact that the world is a game world on a hard drive. The extent by which this can influence Demo(n)Tapes is yet to be seen, except for the few peculiar details on the map of Snordenmark.

7 Enemies, NPCs, Other Objects

Demo(n)Tapes does not treat “enemies” as a fixed faction. Instead, opposition emerges from **misalignment**: competing legitimacy claims, institutional friction, ideological conflict, and the Keeper’s incentives. This chapter defines the main classes of non-player entities and world objects that populate Snordenmark’s scene ecosystem.

7.1 NPC character archetypes (Game Entity characters)

7.1.1 Scene elders (credibility anchors)

Scene elders are high-influence cultural figures who act as reference points for what “counts.” They do not need to be benevolent; their primary function is to be *legibility engines*. They are modelled after controller characters for bands that are no longer active but have made an impact to the scene before the game starts.

Typical behaviours:

- amplify or dismiss bands through endorsement, when the band outputs the right tag that corresponds to their legacy (this happens via scene mechanics, but is narratively delivered via this type of NPC).
- introduce insight into game mechanics, accessible to the players via interacting with the Scene Nexus.

Mechanical role:

- provide the Scene Space backdrop upon which the entire game session builds over
- answer the question “What is TRVE” before players have any input with it

7.1.2 Zine Editors

These are people who convert events into narrative. They are not “press” in a modern sense—more like amateur journalists, rumour hubs, collectors, and scene photographers. They are objective and neutral to the events they describe and report. They are intangible, non-corporeal beings from game play perspective. Not to be confused with actual journalists, who can be interacted with.

Typical behaviours:

- provides a news package to the scene at the beginning of each turn, before the collective stance is locally chosen. The stance determines the scope of information the news are delivered.
- Provides an alternative, although more fragmentary representation of the Scene Map in the form of listening figures and musical influence relationship drawings.
- Platforms the intra-scene conflict approachable and readable for players in the form of gossip mongering and back-and-forth interviews between competing parties.

Mechanical role:

- serving as npc narrators of in-game events

7.1.3 Business owners, venue operators and the like

Different type of structure game entities is controlled by local gate figures of varying agency (from actor to agent to groupie) who serve as narrative interfaces for interacting those structures.

Typical behaviours:

- offer the service of that structure when valid
- become targets of gestation actions, often carrying the structure's resonance tag, when interacting with the structure itself would feel hard to justify at the level of actions
- spread local resonance tags (each venue also carries a mood)

Mechanical role:

- enable meaningful interaction between structures and characters by serving as focus points
- unconventional interaction risks: notoriety, conflict, police attention

7.1.4 The Hole staff and regulars

Even when the Keeper is a player, the shop has staff and regulars who are semi-autonomous carriers of the scene's mood and institutional memory. Even more noteworthy is the tendency of the Keeper's band to work at the Hole, getting exposed as actors beyond the regular band interactions.

Being the Keeper is both a position of strength, and an exposure to potential weakness. Not managing your band members correctly, can lead them to become disgruntled and easily manipulated by others. If a band member has an idea that doesn't get used, they might give it away while serving The Hole.

Typical behaviours:

- enforce "what's stocked" and what gets rotated into attention, having a slight effect on the overall scene orbital influences
- gossip that changes social graph edges between controllers

Mechanical role:

- becomes the interface layer for Keeper and the rest of the players
- acts as a stable "hub entities", even for tag extraction and event triggering

7.1.5 Rival controllers (non-player bands)

Not every band in the scene is player controlled. NPC bands exist to:

- keep the semantic space populated
- prevent the world from feeling like a purely player-made stage

- create baseline pressures and comparisons

Typical behaviours:

- occupy parts of the tag space as competing claims
- create tapes that seed trends (lowercase trve)
- become pawns or allies through trade and promotion interactions

Mechanical role:

- to serve as bot-controlled bands

7.1.6 Law enforcement and authorities (external pressure)

Authorities are not omnipresent; they represent the risk boundary of the scene. They enter the simulation through events and notoriety escalation rather than as constant tactical opponents.

Typical behaviours:

- block certain map nodes from interaction
- search for characters with interactions of 3rd degree permutations
- remove characters for turns or even rounds

Mechanical role:

- push toward end-game collapse states by forcing actors to take more drastic measures to stay in the game
- introduce repercussions on too bombastic actions
- bargain with characters (authorities want to extend their information scope over narrative aspect happenings in exchange for reduced penalties etc).

7.1.7 Social satellites (groupies, partners, hangers-on, strangers from strange lands)

These characters are not “units” so much as contextual modifiers that make small scenes personal and unstable.

Typical behaviours:

- intensify mood trajectories (infatuation, jealousy, conflict)
- become exchange vectors between bands (a social bridge)
- force value conflicts by pulling characters into unwanted contexts

Mechanical role:

- attach to tags (mood/resonance) as embodied consequences
- create unpredictable adjacency shifts in social networks
- “Go write that goth stuff for your goth boyfriend, but don’t shove that shit around here.”

7.2 World objects as semantic entities (non-character Game Entities)

In Demo(n)Tapes, locations and objects are not passive scenery. They are **semantic reservoirs** that carry resonance tags and can be interacted with to extract, confront, or borrow meaning.

7.2.1 Key locations

- **The Hole (record shop / institution)**
 - Primary choke point for promotion and legitimization.
 - Functions as a high-impact tag reservoir and social meeting node.
- **Rehearsal space**
 - The band's private production lab.
 - Hosts VHS track objects, composition state, and rehearsal affordances.
- **Library**
 - General-purpose gestation source.
 - Broad access to low-degree tags and inspiration permutations.
- **Church**
 - A concentrated source of Sacred/anti-sacred conflict dynamics.
 - Especially relevant for re-sacralising mechanics due to transient tag acquisition pressure.
- **Police station**
 - Authority resonance; access is risky.
 - Can spawn high-consequence tags and event triggers.
- **Underground venues**
 - Visibility conversion points.
 - Carry strong local resonance and enforce informal norms.
- **Transit nodes (bus station, port, rail)**
 - Circulation amplifiers.
 - Useful for tape movement, rumor spreading, and opportunistic tag extraction.

7.2.2 Items as entities (tapes and artifacts)

- **VHS tapes (work-in-progress track entities)**
 - Represent rehearsal-state material: mutable, improvable, degradable over time if neglected.
 - Used as the interface object for rehearsal actions.
- **C-cassettes (released demo entities)**
 - Represent committed material that enters circulation.
 - Subject to copying, overwriting, degradation by generation, and institutional interference.
- **Posters, letters, mail parcels (promotion artifacts)**
 - Represent concrete traces of promotion posture.
 - Can be vandalized, removed, or used as evidence in authority escalation.

(Exact item mechanics are specified in 4.10; this chapter defines their role as world entities.)

8. Emergent Institutions and Scene Trajectories

A standard session of *Demo(n)Tapes* does not follow a predefined storyboard. Instead, the game operates as a systemic simulation driven by interacting actors, their available actions, and the consequences that emerge from those actions over time. Narrative is not authored but emerges from the evolving state of the scene.

All player-controlled characters begin with an implicit allegiance to the Hole scene, which functions as the primary cultural and institutional framework of play. Within this framework, controller-class characters (band leaders) exert influence through participation in core systems: creation (gestation/rehearsal/recording), promotion, and interaction with other entities and institutions.

The definition of what is considered TRVE is dynamic and subject to continuous change. As the scene evolves, the definition of what is considered TRVE is dynamic and continuously re-evaluated by the scene through the circulation of demos and Keeper intervention. As this definition shifts, previously aligned bands may become misaligned with the dominant thematic centre.

Over time, the scene may fragment into subscenes because of proselytizing TRVE expressions and competing legitimacy claims. These subscenes form alternative centres of gravity, redirecting player efforts into parallel legitimacy structures that do not contribute to the dominant influence pool. However, subscenes are not inherently secondary; if a subscene accumulates sufficient influence, it may redefine the global standard of TRVE through Keeper turnover.

The continuity of the game is tied to the stability of the Hole as an institutional node. If the Hole loses its functional role as the central point of cultural coordination and gatekeeping, the scene collapses, triggering the end-game condition.

8.1 Session State Axes

The state of the session is represented along two systemic axes:

- **Hegemony ↔ Splintering**

Measures the structural cohesion of the scene.

Hegemony: A single dominant thematic centre; most influence converges toward shared TRVE definitions.

Splintering: Multiple competing subscenes with independent gravity centres and weak mutual alignment.

- Primary drivers:
 - Proselytizing TRVE tag-pairs
 - Keeper interventions reinforcing or destabilizing central authority
 - Divergence of tag usage across circulating demos
- System impact:
 - Determines formation and persistence of subscenes
 - Affects efficiency of influence accumulation (centralized vs fragmented)

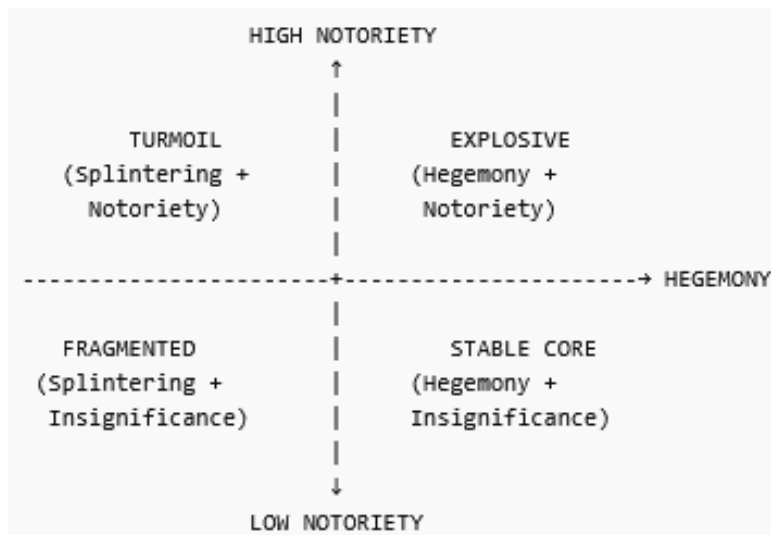
- **Notoriety ↔ Insignificance**

Measures the scene's visibility and pressure from external systems.

Insignificance: Low visibility; limited external interference; slow cultural propagation.

Notoriety: High visibility; increased risk of authority intervention and systemic disruption.

- Primary drivers:
 - Promotional actions and circulation volume
 - Extreme actions (e.g., high-degree tag permutations, illegal acts)
 - Media amplification and institutional attention
- System impact:
 - Governs probability and intensity of authority events
 - Contributes to end-game collapse conditions



These axes are derived values calculated from the current state of the scene and are used to interpret overall system stability rather than to directly control individual actions.

8.2 End game scenarios

Every session of Demo(n)Tapes ends when the scene reaches a collapse condition. **The winner of the game is the player whose contributions to the Scene were the most influential, whose releases exert the greatest gravity on the final scene map.**

The check to see if the scene collapses happen before the check for the next Keeper takes place, so a failing scene cannot be inherited. If the scene is determined to end, the game goes to the last round of gameplay, “the apocalypse round”. The Keeper stays the same, trying to minimize their losses at The Hole, while other players try to minimize the backlash at their end.

7.2.1 With a bang

The scene collapses through external suppression when notoriety reaches a level that triggers sustained intervention from external authorities. As notoriety increases, external pressure escalates, disrupting circulation, promotion, and participation. By collapse, key actors are either removed from play or unable to act effectively. Snitching

is a thing. Going into hiding is a thing. Carrying an axe in your backpack to go for a cigarette is a thing.

8.2.1.1 Optional Outcome: Countercultural Overthrow (Very Rare)

In extremely rare (perhaps only hypothetical) cases, the scene may accumulate sufficient power to overcome the societal system opposing it. In this outcome, the scene eclipses the surrounding society in influence, preventing suppression and redefining the dominant cultural framework.

This outcome is intentionally extremely unlikely and functions as a hidden or edge-case victory condition.

8.2.2 With a whimper

The scene collapses through loss of distinction when its defining characteristics become indistinguishable from surrounding culture.

This occurs when TRVE loses meaning due to overextension, normalization, or excessive alignment with mainstream aesthetics.

When everything is just talk and posturing, or when the aesthetic and performance align with something perceived as radio friendly to a point in which the mainstream media begins to absorb and normalize the scene.

This is hard to define. So, let's stay vague for now. In a nutshell, the idea is that if producing a demo tape succeeds automatically, regardless of tag composition, the scene is probably dead.

8.2.2.1 Optional Outcome: Cultural Assimilation Victory (Very Rare)

In rare cases, the scene may achieve stability through full assimilation into the broader culture without losing internal legitimacy. In this outcome, societal systems can no longer target the scene, as its values have been integrated into the mainstream (not the other way around).

This outcome is highly unlikely and represents an edge-case transformation rather than standard success.

9. Technical definitions, Tech guide*

9.1 Platforms, versions

For the time being, Demo(N)Tapes and its future-scope projects are PC releases on Windows platform. It has been noted, however, that most of the gameplay loop would translate more than well to smart devices.

9.2 Control Scheme

Mouse and keyboard.

9.3 Limitations

As a one-man project, the system is more important than how it is conveyed to the player for now. "It needs to work on principle at this stage".

10. Business definitions*

Use this space to elaborate where you are going with the project after the project course and the thesis.

10.1 In-app purchases

NO.

10.2 DLC packs

It is plausible that at some stage the theatre of operation in the game starts to expand to continental Europe, with a few alternative scenes becoming available for gameplay. Expansions, should they materialize, would include “The Fauxian Connection” and another to simulate post-soviet countries. The Fauxian Scene would be modelled after the French black metal scene of the 90s, where obscurity and introversion was fetishised even further than in Norway.

11. Outsourced/Bought Assets

Topics with () usually extended to separate detailed documents, in this project can be simply summarized*

12. Technical Terms

Term Definition

Actor	Semi-autonomous character acting within a collective (e.g., band members).
Snordenmark (SNO)	Fictional Nordic amalgam nation and primary setting.
Keeper	Player currently leading; runs the record shop and wields powerful scene-shaping actions.
Elites	Hardcore listeners forming the credibility core of the scene. Elites are hypersensitive to authenticity and react very badly to things such as simulacra.
Posers	Mainstream audience reflecting commercial appeal.
Scene	The Snordenmark black metal subculture and its fluctuating thematic centre.
SEMM91	Scandinavian Extreme Metal Manager '91; planned expanded single-player version.
Year (Round)	Full cycle of four seasons.
Season (Turn)	One playable time segment within a year.
End-game Event	Cataclysmic event that collapses the scene and ends the game.
Game Entity	Any object that can hold tags (characters, buildings, environments, tracks).
Collective	A group of game entities acting together (e.g., a band, a recording).
Controller	High-agency character; defines collective actions (e.g., band leaders).
Agent	Low-autonomy helper character specializing in 1–2 tasks.
Groupie	Attachment/stat-boost character linked to another character or tag.
Track	A single recorded piece composed of ideas.
Demo Tape	A collection of tracks; main goal of the game loop.
Transient Tag Slot	Storage slot for a temporary, uncommitted tag.
Collective Action	A unified action chosen for an entire collective (e.g., rehearse, gestate).
Character Action	An individual's action within the constraints of the collective action.
Gestation Actions	Actions for extracting tags, creating ideas, and exchanging concepts.

Term Definition

Rehearsal Actions	Actions improving conveyance and developing tracks inside the rehearsal space.
Promotional Actions	Actions that spread material beyond Keeper control.
Keeper Actions	High-impact actions used to shape the scene's expectations or sabotage others.
Compose Action	Begins or extends a track by placing ideas; defines the root of the track.
Rehearse Action	Improves a character's conveyance rating on a track.
Rest Action	Skips activity to remove Tired status and avoid strain penalties.
Aspect	A trait capable of hosting tags (e.g., guitar, corpse paint, lyricism).
Idea	An instantiated aspect carrying one or more tags.
Root (Idea)	The first idea placed on a track; defines its initial structure.
Conveyance	Normalized float describing how clearly an idea is delivered (0.0–1.0).
Novelty Factor	Influence bonus applied the first time an aspect is used in the scene.
Tag	Core emotional/ideological semantic marker.
Anti-Tag	The opposing tag in a tag-pair.
Associated Tag	Tags thematically linked to the base tag.
Resonance Tag	Long-term identity tag; unlimited use.
Mood Tag	Short-term emotional tag; limited uses per turn.
Conviction Tag	Deep belief tag: multiple uses possible but repeated use becomes proselytizing.
Transient Tag	Temporary tag acquired from interactions; must be used or it fades.
In-Season Tag	Tags naturally available during specific seasons (e.g., morbid in autumn).
Special Tag	Rare or risky tag obtained from specific events.
Tag-Pair	Combination of a tag and its anti-tag or special structured combination.
Re-sacralising Tag-Pair	Core TRVE-defining black metal tag-pair (tag + anti-tag).
De-sacralising Tag-Pair	Tag + NULL tag pair (death metal logic; future scope).
Sacralising Tag-Pair	Double-tag pair (doom metal logic; future scope).
Simulacra	An emulated version of a mood tag when used beyond its limit, or without the required mood available in the first place. For Posers.
TRVE (uppercase)	Content mechanically legitimized by re-sacralising tag-pair.
trve (lowercase)	Scene-conforming surface-level aesthetic or trend.

Term Definition

Gravity	Pull exerted by TRVE tags; shapes the scene's thematic centre.
Gravity Factor	Amount of thematic pull exerted by a TRVE tag or pair.
Tired Status	Condition acquired from taking a third character action in a season.
Strain Penalty	Negative effect specific to each action type upon overexertion.
All Over the Place	Gestation strain penalty; forces transient tag resolution or replacement.
Burnout	Rehearsal strain penalty: character loses access to mood tag for the turn.
Too on the Nose	Promotional strain penalty; forces negative interaction with convictional anti-tag.
Overreach	Keeper strain penalty: blocks influence gain and Pull replenishment.
Influence	Abstract measure of standing within the scene.
Influence Points	Quantified influence accumulated per actions/tags/tracks.
Pull	Expendable Keeper resource used to pay for Keeper actions.
Generation (of Copy)	The duplication depth of a tape; each generation reduces conveyance.
the 2:3 rule	An entity can make two actions and one extra at a cost.
the rule of 7	The number 7 serves as a standard for sets, or as a cap of sets. For example, there are 7 tag – anti-tag pairs, and a band (in this game) can have 7 members at most.
scene splintering	A scene can form within a scene, based on a proselytizing TRVE tag pair.
VHS tapes	Represent the bands current handling of a given track, built over time in the rehearsal space. During live shows, bands perform their tracks at the level of the VHS tape, not the demo tape release. VHS tapes erode slowly while they sit on the shelf, representing the band losing touch with their old material.
C-cassettes	These tapes have varying runtimes, and they can be over written.

Tag – Anti-tag pairs

Tag	Anti-Tag	Axis
Profane	Sacred	Transgression vs Sanctification
Cold	Warm	Emotional Distance vs Immediacy
Raw	Honed	Expression vs Refinement
Fast	Slow	Urgency vs Deliberation
Malevolent	Benevolent	Hostility vs Altruism
Morbid	Vital	Death Fixation vs Life Force
Void	Meaning	Nihilism vs Purpose

Tag Permutations

Tag	Degree 0	Degree 1	Degree 2	Degree 3
Profane	Irreverent	Defiant	Desecrating	Sacrilegious
Cold	Distant	Aloof	Bitter	Glacial
Raw	Rough	Unpolished	Primitive	Brutal
Fast	Urgent	Driving	Frenetic	Blistering
Malevolent	Irritable	Spiteful	Vindictive	Malicious
Morbid	Gloomy	Macabre	Funereal	Sepulchral
Void	Hollow	Nihilistic	Bleak	Abyssal

Tag	Degree 0	Degree 1	Degree 2	Degree 3
Sacred	Reverent	Devout	Consecrated	Sanctified
Warm	Familial	Welcoming	Embracing	Fervent
Honed	Polished	Refined	Precise	Masterful
Slow	Measured	Heavy	Dragging	Monolithic
Benevolent	Kind	Generous	Protective	Compassionate
Vital	Lively	Energetic	Thriving	Exuberant
Meaning	Purposeful	Devoted	Zealous	Transcendent

Tag – Adjacencies

Tag	Adjacencies
Profane	Malevolent, Raw, Void
Cold	Void, Morbid, Slow
Raw	Profane, Fast, Malevolent
Fast	Raw, Malevolent, Vital
Malevolent	Profane, Raw, Fast
Morbid	Cold, Slow, Void
Void	Cold, Morbid, Profane

Tag	Adjacencies
Sacred	Meaning, Slow, Honed
Warm	Vital, Benevolent, Honed
Honed	Sacred, Meaning, Warm
Slow	Sacred, Cold, Morbid
Benevolent	Warm, Vital, Meaning
Vital	Warm, Fast, Benevolent
Meaning	Sacred, Benevolent, Honed

13. Systems reference (outdated – non-authoritative)

Below is a list of all the systems in the game, followed by a short definition of the system, along with a scope flag. The scope flags are

- **Core (Demo(n)Tapes):** Must exist for the game to exist
- **Optional (Demo(n)Tapes):** can exist, not required
- **Expanded (SEMM91/Later):** belongs to the expanded project scope, to be ignored for now
- **Unwritten:** This flag is self-correcting and shouldn't exist when the GDD is finished.

Below the system flag, **System Boundaries** are defined for each entry: Input, Output, Definition/Restriction notes.

A. Time, Turn, Resolution

1. Season/Year – CORE

Four seasons (turns) form one year (round); evaluation and keeper changes happen yearly (at the end of each round).

- inputs:** current *season index*; round/year counter; season order logic.
- outputs:** season transitions, year transitions; triggers for end-of-turn and -round phases.
- does not** resolve actions, decide Keeper, keep score of influence.

2. Asynchronous Declarations & End-of-Turn resolution – CORE

Players declare actions without seeing others' choices; actions resolve together at end of the turn, including shared-target interactions.

- inputs:** a player's declared action set; current public state; resolution rules/exceptions; keeper interventions
- outputs:** resolved turn timeline; updated world state, public-facing splashes/events
- does not** behave as a network transport, keep long term score, trigger end game

3. End-of-Year Evaluation System – CORE

Overall progress is evaluated every four turns, and the most influential operator is declared Keeper.

- inputs:** per-player tallies from four turns; scene state snapshot; criteria
- outputs:** Next Keeper; year summary; rollovers/reset of year-scope
- does not** resolve turn-scope conflicts, engage with the UI or tape replication

B. Agency, Entities, Action Economy

4. Game Entity System – CORE

All meaningful world objects function as entities that hold tags and traits.

- i. **inputs:** entity definitions (type: character, structure, track, tape); tag reservoirs; persistence?
- ii. **outputs:** entity world model, tag ownership references, interaction eligibility
- iii. **does not** do actions, keep score or authority/keeper logic

5. Collective System – CORE

Bands and other collectives have collective states that determine which kinds of actions the members of those collectives can take.

- i. **inputs:** membership sets; controller chooses collective action input (gestate/rehearse/promote/other)
- ii. **outputs:** allowed character action set; collective-held states/traits/aspects/ideas.

6. Role & Agency Hierarchy System – CORE

Controllers, Actors, Agents and Groupies represent descending degrees of agency.

- i. **inputs:** character type (controller/actor/agent/groupie); attachments; permissions.
- ii. **outputs:** per character: actions/contributions/modifications.

7. Action Economy: 2:3 Rule – CORE

Two free actions, third at a cost (fatigue and risk)

- i. **inputs:** acting game entity, target game entity, third action attempted flag
- ii. **outputs:** acting game entity update (actions left, eligibility for strain penalties, tag extraction), target game entity update (damage etc).
- iii. **does not** resolve actions outcomes, or influence how strain penalties work

8. Tiredness & Rest – CORE

Third action creates the Tired status; resting clears tiredness.

- i. **inputs:** character tiredness status, rest action flag
- ii. **outputs:** game entity update for next turn
- iii. **does not** implement penalties to actions

9. Strain – CORE

Overexertion triggers action-specific penalties (All Over the Place, Burnout, Too on the Nose, Overreach).

- i. **inputs:** action over-ride when overexertion triggered
- ii. **outputs:** outcome with penalties
- iii. **does not** resolve standard action outcome

C. Creation Pipeline: Gestation → Rehearsal → Recording

10. Gestation System – CORE

Characters interact with locations/entities to extract resonance into transient tags and attach tags to aspects to form ideas.

- i. **inputs:** selected location/entity; extractor character; current tag slots.
- ii. **outputs:** tag inventory update; target game entity update.

11. Rehearsal System – CORE

Ideas are assembled into tracks; rehearsal actions improve conveyance and develop material before committing it to a demo.

- i. **inputs:** VHS; contributed ideas; rehearse actions; aspects.
- ii. **outputs:** track composition state update; conveyance changes; “raw” vs “composed” status change.
- iii. **does not** interact with TRVE evaluation on global scale

12. Recording System (Demo commit) – CORE

Recording commits selected tracks to a demo tape (C-Cassette) via a recording action. Recording can overwrite another tape.

- i. **inputs:** VHS; C-cassette entity chosen; overwriting something logic.
- ii. **outputs:** a new demo tape object, or an overwritten demo tape object.

13. VHS Work-in-Progress Track System – CORE

Tracks exist as rehearsal state objects, symbolized by camcorder takes on the last time a track has been rehearsed. These VHS tapes erode in time, representing the band losing the edge over its execution as the track remains unrehearsed.

- i. **inputs:** a list of VHS objects
- ii. **outputs:** updated VHS object states

14. Sketchy Track Constraint System – CORE

Tracks recorded while not fully composed gain a “sketchy” trait that caps conveyance and keeps them raw.

- i. **inputs:** this is an override that forces change to recording system.
- ii. **outputs:** same as recording system

D. Semantic Core: Tags, Pairs, TRVE/trve, Gravity

15. Seven Tag - anti-Tag axes with permutations – CORE

Tags define the games sematic space and serve as building blocks of the tracks.

- i. **inputs:** a tag gameObject.
- ii. **outputs:** relevant tag relationships.

16. Tag Slot System (Resonance/Mood/Conviction/Transient) – Core

Entities carry tags in functional categories, where they can be engaged with different usage constraints (unlimited, limited, risky repetition, decaying).

- i. **inputs:** tag acquisitions; per turn usage counts; conflict checks with anti-tags; expiry timers for transient tags.
- ii. **outputs:** slot states; usage eligibility; simulacra/proselytizing triggers

17. Tag Permutation & Ownership System – CORE

Tags manifest as permutations, which are owned by the players who first play them.

- i. **inputs:** a tag + permutation; player identity; tag-context.
- ii. **outputs:** permutation instance to scene space; ownership; semantic claims
- iii. **does not** resolve where the permutation comes from

18. Transient Tag Decay & Pinning System – CORE

Transient tags must be used quickly or they evaporate. A transient tag cannot conflict with the conviction tag.

- i. **inputs:** a character game entity -> check its transient tag under the hood
- ii. **outputs:** transient tag state update

19. Tag-Pair System

Specific structured combinations of tags are required for legitimacy criteria and genre logic.

- i. **inputs:** a list of tags on the same recording
- ii. **outputs:** synchronicity of those tags in varying mechanics, **including the next two:**

20. Re-sacralising Tag-Pair System (Blackened Legitimacy) – Core

TRVE black metal requires a re-sacralising tag pair. Without it, the elites ignore the record, bar Keeper intervention.

- i. **inputs:** as Tag-Pair System
- ii. **outputs:** TRVE state

21. TRVE vs trve System – CORE (the semantics require revision)

Lowercase trve is current scene fashion that the posers appreciate (usually represented by one of the tags in the TRVE tag-pair). Uppercase TRVE contains both tags and draws in the Elites (street credibility). This test is a one-time test upon release.

- i. **inputs:** a record

- ii. **outputs:** influence and gravity on release

22. Gravity System – CORE (this is going to be a complex calculation)

TRVE tag-pairs exert a gravity towards anything that resonate with its permutation and to a lesser degree the Tag itself.

- i. **inputs:** all records on the scene map
- ii. **outputs:** updates the scene map

23. Proselytizing & Splintering System – OPTIONAL

Overuse of conviction permutations inside TRVE expressions can cause splintering in the scene with their own gravity centres.

- i. **inputs:** this is an override that awakes in system 21 if numerous conviction tags are present via system 16.
- ii. **outputs:** establishes a subscene that persists if it manages to draw elites.

24. Simulacra System – OPTIONAL

Overuse of mood tags risks producing simulacra that are mood tags that the posers accept as genuine, but the elites hate.

- i. **inputs:** override of 21 in case of simulacra present in the recording
- ii. **outputs:** a record that behaves against scene logic

E. Scene, Social Power, Gatekeeping

25. Keeper Role System – CORE

A leading controller player becomes the Keeper yearly; The Keeper cannot produce new material and must instead serve as the scene police.

- i. **inputs:** list of players
- ii. **outputs:** new keeper (with influence amount of pull resource)

26. Keeper Pull Resource System – CORE (fashion this based on other actions, earlier, no reinventing the wheel)

Keeper has a spendable resource (Pull) derived from influence; Keeper actions consume Pull and can induce Overreach.

- i. **inputs:** keeper pull, desired action
- ii. **outputs:** new pull amount, outcome of action

27. Keeper Intervention System – CORE

Keeper can legitimize, suppress, reframe, “lose”, or take credit for others’ output, modelling informal cultural gatekeeping.

- i. **inputs:** keeper pull, a record existing in scene space
- ii. **outputs:** the chosen record with adjusted attributes, new pull amount

28. Elite vs Posers Social Dualism System – CORE (Elites and Posers are Optional ATM; this might be redundant before we are using record deals and such, beyond the scope of the tape trading scene). We do not simulate poserdom before “selling out” can even become an option. Right now, the audience is the performers instead.

Elites grant credibility and reject simulacra; posers represent commercial appeal—success is evaluated through this tension.

- i. **inputs:** a fresh demo
- ii. **outputs:** scene map hierarchy output

29. The Hole / Record Shop Institutional System – CORE

The record shop concentrates promotional/scene power and is controlled by the Keeper, acting as an institutional choke point.

- i. **inputs:** keeper action system communicates directly with this system
- ii. **outputs:** tweaks the existing scene hierarchy
- iii. **does not** produce new material in any way

30. Ideological Scene Map System (3D thematic map) – CORE

The scene is represented as a 3D ideological map where demo tapes float and the current TRVE composition is visible.

- i. **inputs:** all demos that have listeners
- ii. **outputs:** a nice, clear visual representation of the game state

31. Auditive Representation System – OPTIONAL

Hovering/interaction with TRVE tags on the scene map plays loops representing the sound of TRVE; useful for vibe, not mechanically required.

- i. **inputs:** the output of 30. or a single record or a selection of records via UI
- ii. **outputs:** different .ogg files played in sync

F. Promotion, Visibility, Circulation

32. Promotion System (actions for visibility) – CORE

Players spread their material via posters, mail, and gigs; lack of visibility makes bands vulnerable to Keeper control and obscurity.

- i. **inputs:** a record on a C-cassette, or a VHS cassette, target(s)
- ii. **outputs:** a level of visibility (that should have a metric and readable on the map)
- iii. **does not** produce copies

33. Tape Circulation & Copying System – CORE

Recorded demos enter circulation and can be copied, overwritten, or redistributed; access to copies enables influence and sabotage.

- i. **inputs:** an instance of a demo tape (C-cassette)
- ii. **outputs:** a possibly altered demo tape with local level of degradation

34. Generation Degradation System – CORE

Each copy generation reduces conveyance, diminishing clarity and impact as distribution widens.

- i. **inputs:** all instances of the same demo tape
- ii. **outputs:** the overall conveyance throughout the entire map

- iii. **does not** modify anything

35. Public Info Access System – CORE

Players can only view/hear others' output to the extent it becomes public (promotion or scene-map presence), maintaining partial visibility, unless they have a personal access to the demo tape in question. If the tape is on the scene map, they can access it with degradation.

- i. **inputs:** a demo tape at the available degrade level
- ii. **outputs:** the demo's tags as obscured by level of degradation

G. Progression, Endgame, Collapse

36. Influence Accumulation System – CORE

Actions and semantic success produce influence points; influence helps determine Keeper and access to power.

- i. **inputs:** a fresh demo after evaluation (28), recheck each round with conveyance
- ii. **outputs:** into character score after each check (34)

37. End-Game Collapse System OPTIONAL

The game ends via a cataclysmic scene collapse driven by notoriety backlash or loss/dilution of meaning, pushed organically by the engine.

- i. **inputs:** a list of active scene actors
- ii. **outputs:** determination of whether the scene can still act

38. TRVE Dilution / Loss-of-Meaning Failure Mode – OPTIONAL

A pathway to collapse where "trve" loses distinction (too broad, too diverse, too normalized), eroding gravity and legitimacy.

- i. **inputs:** input the entire scene
- ii. **outputs:** if the scene can still be described as an entity

H. Items & Item Mechanisms

39. C-Cassette Item System – UNWRITTEN

C-cassettes have runtimes (46/60/90), can be overwritten, and constrain releases; needs formal system description in 4.10. This is an extra system that tracks where the cassette has been, and what it has contained, and whether the outdated information is on any level valid. (Note: a future version of the game could have a special character type that can access this information with a clandestine action type)

- i. **inputs:** a demo tape instance after system 33, cassette runtime, overwrite actions
- ii. **outputs:** cassette history update

40. Item and area Access/Availability System – UNWRITTEN

Implied scarcity/availability of tapes and materials; transportation costs; not yet

defined but referenced as “soft economy”. For the time being, this can be simplified to the question “Does the Keeper approve”, in which case some of the demo tape has a wider availability.

- i. **inputs:** a fresh demo tape, keeper stance
- ii. **outputs:** a fresh demo tape with heightened or lowered conveyance

I. Multiplayer Session Model

41. Multiplayer Session System – UNWRITTEN – CORE

mechanics assume online multiplayer, but specifics aren't defined in 4.11.

J. Future Scope

42. De-sacralising Tag-Pair (Death Metal Logic) – EXPANDED

43. Sacralising Tag-Pair (Doom Metal Logic) – EXPANDED